

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called 'The Chapter on Bearing the Great Drum'

Ārya-Mahābherī-hāraka-parivarta-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra · Toh 222 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་རྒྱ་ཆེ་ཆེན་པོའི་ལཱེ་ཞུས་བ་བྱ་ཐག་པ་ཆེན་པོའི་མཛན།

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called "The Chapter on Bearing the Great Drum," known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-Mahābherī-hāraka-parivarta-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra and in Tibetan as Pakpa Ngabo Chenpo Chenpö Leu Shyejawa Tekpa Chenpo Do, is a Mahāyāna sūtra set in the Jeta Grove at Śrāvastī, where the Buddha addresses a vast assembly of monastics, bodhisattvas, gods, nāgas, and laypeople. The text's evocative title centers on the image of a great drum, which in Buddhist literature often serves as a metaphor for the far-reaching and awakening power of the Dharma. It is Toh 222 in the Kangyur, belonging to the general category of Mahāyāna sūtras, and is preserved in both its Sanskrit title and Tibetan translation, attesting to its transmission through the classical Indian and Tibetan canonical traditions.

In the language of India: Ārya-Mahābherī-hāraka-parivarta-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra. In the Tibetan language: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called "The Chapter on Bearing the Great Drum." First fascicle.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, in the prince's park at Śrāvastī, together with a great Saṅgha of one thousand two hundred and fifty monks, and together with many hundreds of thousands of bodhisattvas as well. Gods, nāgas, yakṣas, and many gandharvas were also present. Many hundreds of thousands of laymen and laywomen were likewise present. Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods), and the four world-guardians were also present. In short, monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen together with many bodhisattvas gathered from world-systems in the ten directions were present as well.

Now the Tathāgata was teaching the Dharma in this manner — setting forth, in the midst of all four assemblies, a discourse on the Dharma in these words:

Existence holds pleasure and pain alike;
neither is exhausted, neither is permanent.

Therefore, in order to abandon both pleasure and pain,
nirvāṇa is the supreme bliss.

Here it is asked: what is the reason it is said that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, was dwelling in Śrāvastī together with only five hundred monks? The reason should be explained. How is it that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha — who is renowned for possessing a vast retinue, who is the chief of a vast retinue, whose retinue is ever inseparable from him, and who commands many wondrous qualities and miraculous displays — if things were as said, should have a retinue of no more than five hundred? If that were so, surely the Blessed One would have a retinue of tens of millions.

To this it is again said: because of his power to govern all who are to be trained, the Tathāgata was dwelling in Śrāvastī together with five hundred monks — this is expressed in those words. Consider the analogy of a mother who, carrying her child on her back, travels from her own land to another country, and says "the village is near now" simply to encourage and comfort her child. In just the same way, might it not be that the Buddha Bhagavān, who protects and watches over all beings, spoke of being together with merely five hundred monks as an encouragement? To this it is answered: monks, this Dharma discourse has been recited three times. Therefore you should understand that those referred to as "approximately five hundred monks" are the foremost among men — it does not mean anything else. For example, just as each bull of the finest herd has a group of cattle, so too each of these foremost men has five hundred disciples, and each one of them again has five hundred and five hundred disciples. Therefore "approximately five hundred" refers to the great śrāvakas (hearers) — that is, great Kāśyapa, and likewise Ānanda, and the rest of the approximately five hundred great śrāvakas, all of whom were arhats with exhausted defilements, free from mental afflictions, self-mastered, great elephants among sages, fully accomplished, supremely liberated of mind, supremely liberated through wisdom, who had done what had to be done, accomplished the task, laid down the burden, attained their own aim, utterly exhausted all bondage to existence, and whose minds were supremely liberated through perfect knowledge — who had followed through on the highest perfection of all mental mastery, together with those beyond training, those in training who had entered the stream, those who return once, those abiding in the fruit of non-return, and countless others possessing the

qualities of exhausted defilements — together with these many assemblies of monks.

Together with these, there were also innumerable and immeasurable great bodhisattvas (bodhisattvas mahāsattvas) possessed of a hundred thousand qualities, who had come from the ten directions — bodhisattvas whose number even Mañjuśrī, let alone any calculator or student of calculation, could not reckon, and whom neither śrāvakas nor pratyekabuddhas could count. Among them were the great bodhisattva Mahāsthāmaprāpta, the great bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara, Mañjuśrī the Ever-Youthful, the great bodhisattva Maitreya, and many others — an assembly of bodhisattvas, measureless and beyond counting, who had entered into this great earth like the bark that peels from a great tree, just as strips of bark emerge from a mighty tree. The number of these measureless and innumerable great bodhisattvas could not be declared even by a calculator or by those belonging to the great lineage of calculators, and they had come from beyond. There was also the assembly of sisters — the fully ordained nun Dhammadinnā and others, Mṛgāramatā Viśākhā, the noble queen Mallikā and others, as well as many laywomen, and many laymen such as the householder Anāthapiṇḍada and others. The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, was seated in the midst of all these great assemblies, and the Blessed One was teaching the doors of the Dharma.

Then at that time, Prasenajit, the king of the land of Kosala, rose from his bed and thought: "I shall go into the presence of the Blessed One." And as he rose from his bed, the great drums were beaten and the conches were blown, and the many parasols, victory banners, and pennants raised on high blazed through the sky like the light of the sun. Now the Blessed One, knowing all things, spoke then to Ānanda: "Ānanda, what is this sound — the beating of the great drums and the blowing of the conches?" Ānanda replied: "Blessed One, the virtuous king Prasenajit, the guardian of the realm, has come here, and the great sound of the beating of the drums is what is being heard." The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, why are the drums sounding?" Ānanda replied: "The king is coming to pay his respects to the Protector of the Śākyas, and is announcing to his own army: 'Come and hear a teaching in the presence of the Blessed One!'" The Blessed One then said: "Ānanda, you too should beat the drum of the Dharma and blow the conch of the Dharma, for I shall now teach the sūtra called the Great Drum." Ānanda replied: "Blessed One, I have never before heard of a sūtra called the Great Drum. What is this Dharma called the Great Drum?" The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, do you think you will come to

know it? For now, if even all these great bodhisattvas who have come from the ten directions do not know so much as four syllables of this sūtra of the Great Drum, how could you, who have not heard it before, possibly know it?" Ānanda said: "Blessed One, it is truly marvelous that this Dharma is so difficult to find." The Tathāgata declared: "Ānanda, this sūtra is indeed exceedingly difficult to find. This great sūtra of the Great Drum is, for example, like the udumbara flower, which is found only rarely in the world." Ānanda said: "Blessed One, is this not the nature of reality of all buddhas, all Blessed Ones?" The Blessed One declared: "This is indeed the nature of reality of all the buddhas, all the Blessed Ones — those of the past, those yet to come, and those of the present." Ānanda said:

"If this is the nature of reality of all buddhas, all the Blessed Ones, then why did those buddhas, those Blessed Ones, not teach and expound it in each of their own buddha-fields? And why have these supreme persons — these great bodhisattvas — come here?"

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, consider, for example, a monk who dwells as a forest-dweller — dwelling in some mountain, on the bank of a stream, or in a cave. When he sets out from that dwelling place at dawn to go to a village or city for alms, he might see a snake, or a dog, or a corpse — whether of one not yet dead or of one already dead. Having seen it, he might think: 'Alas! Alas! I too have long been wandering in saṃsāra, and in the course of that wandering I have experienced such states as these — so now I am truly done with existence!' Then at some other time, through certain joyful teachings, his mind might become at ease; and then again, unexpectedly, he might see a corpse once more. Seeing it, he becomes spiritually stirred, and wanders back through fields, towns, mountains, and the margins of valleys. As he wanders about in this way, he may see a corpse that has been dead for one day or two days — and so forth as before, up to the point of seeing a human corpse — and by that very sight alone he directly realizes the supreme fruit of arhatship.

In just the same way, in other world-realms, the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, do not speak even a word of suffering, do not speak even a word of impermanence, and do not speak of selflessness or of impurity. Why is this? Because this is the nature of reality in those realms. There, all the buddhas, the Blessed Ones who dwell, address the bodhisattvas, the great bodhisattvas, who are present in their respective buddha-fields for the sake of their purpose, in these words: 'Sons of good family, for the sake of sentient beings the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, undergo hardship by appearing in a buddha-field

like this — a defiled field, one possessing the five degeneracies. Therefore, sons of good family, you too should train in just this way.' Thus they inspire and guide them. Then those bodhisattvas, wishing to behold these buddhas and wishing to pay homage to them, are shown the way by those buddhas — and on that account they come to this world-realm of Endurance. Having come, some of them attain the first ground; others attain up through the seventh, eighth, ninth, and tenth grounds."

"Ānanda, for this reason the sūtra called the Great Drum is exceedingly difficult to find — and that is also why this entire assembly, gathered from the ten directions, wishes to hear it."

Ānanda said: "Blessed One, excellent! Excellent that all have come! Excellent indeed that they have come! May all of them obtain this sūtra, so exceedingly difficult to find!"

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, since this sūtra is not common to all as an ordinary teaching, do not say 'Excellent that all have come! Excellent that they have come!'"

Ānanda said: "Blessed One, why should I not say 'Excellent that all have come! Excellent that they have come!'"

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, this sūtra is profound and difficult to penetrate, difficult to trust and difficult to have faith in — it is a secret of the buddhas. Therefore, Ānanda, do not say 'Excellent that all have come! Excellent that they have come!' to all who have come and all who are yet to come."

Ānanda said: "Blessed One, what then?"

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, it is like this: when Prasenajit, king of Kosala, sounds the great drum and strikes the battle-gong at the time of going to war — is that not the signal for the entire assembled army? So it is, Blessed One. So it is."

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, that very great drum — whenever king Prasenajit of Kosala sounds it at the time of engaging the enemy army in battle, when the sound of the great drum arises, many sentient beings who hear it will not rejoice. Why is that? For other sentient beings of the chaff-class, upon hearing that sound, it will cause them either to die or to experience the suffering of facing death. Ānanda, for that reason, this sūtra called the Great Drum is something even you, Ānanda, do not fully know. Why is that? Ānanda,

those who belong to the vehicle of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas will not come to trust this sūtra — this sūtra of the gateway to the Dharma. Ānanda, for that very reason, just as when king Prasenajit of Kosala sounds the great drum at the time of going to war, so too this sūtra of the Great Drum is a secret of the buddhas — it will be proclaimed at the time of the buddhas."

Then at that moment the Blessed One called out to the elder Mahākāśyapa and, having called him, spoke these words: "Kāśyapa, are these monks people of faith, in accordance with right conduct, and possessed of power?"

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, what is the meaning of this?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, those who are not like sentient beings that are mere chaff — they are the ones who will listen to this sūtra called the Great Drum."

Kāśyapa said: "Blessed One, for that reason even the elder Mahāmaudgalyāyana disparages himself, and, Blessed One, if monks such as these were to exist, how much more need one speak of a Tathāgata's presence when even I myself would not be present among them — monks who have broken their moral discipline and who are without moral discipline simply do not exist here. Blessed One, all of this assembly observes moral discipline and acts in accordance with right conduct. Within the midst of this assembly, they are like nothing but the heartwood of sandalwood."

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, although this entire assembly observes moral discipline and acts in accordance with right conduct, are they nonetheless skilled in the words of intended meaning?"

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, what is meant by 'the words of intended meaning'?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, 'the words of intended meaning' refers to this: that which is called 'the Tathāgata has passed completely into nirvāṇa' — what is meant by this, here and now, is that the Tathāgata is permanent, stable, at peace, everlasting, and that although he has completely passed into nirvāṇa he does not decline. This sūtra is called 'the words of intended meaning.' Kāśyapa, this sūtra of discordant teachings, this pure and luminous one — lesser sentient beings must come to understand it through hundreds and thousands of reasons and arguments. Kāśyapa, therefore you too, for the time being, should look carefully at this assembly and understand them."

Then at that moment the elder Mahākāśyapa looked to see what manner of beings these fortunate ones in the assembly were. Then in that very instant all the sentient beings who were not of broad scope, and those of the vehicle of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and those bodhisattvas who had newly entered the vehicle — all of them disparaged themselves. It was just as when, in a great assembly of champions, a royal champion capable of defeating a thousand warriors rises from his seat and proclaims: "Who here is bold enough and fit to engage me in combat?"

Then all those sentient beings in that assembly who were unfit to engage in combat said to themselves, "We will be slain — we are incapable of fighting alongside him," and, having disparaged themselves in this way, they fell completely silent. Then, if that champion found no rival combatant there, he stood at the battlefield as the peerless hero, his weapons at the ready. In just the same way, all those beings in that assembly who were not of the royal lineage — those of the vehicle of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and those bodhisattvas who had newly entered the vehicle — they too abandoned hope, saying to themselves: "Even as the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, pass into nirvāṇa, this Teacher's proclamation that 'I am permanent, stable, at peace, and everlasting' is something we cannot comprehend." And why was that? Because for a long time they had been people who cultivated views that undermine the view of the Teacher himself. And so beings of lesser scope, upon hearing this pure sūtra, departed. From all the ten directions, whatever śrāvakas, those of the vehicle of pratyekabuddhas, and those newly entered into the vehicle of the bodhisattvas had gathered — out of all of those who had assembled from each of those directions, only a tenth part, a hundredth part, a thousandth part, a ten-thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part, and an innumerable fraction remained gathered there.

Now, what kind of laymen were present there who were not like mere outer bark but were like the heartwood of sandalwood? Those who kept the five bases of training; those who kept the eight bases of training; those who recited the three; those of the fourteenth; those of the fifteenth — up to those who had well taken up the eight limbs of the half-month, the eighth day, and the half-month of miracles — those who gave, spoke kindly, acted for the benefit of others, and were harmonious in aim. Such a person, if ten years of famine came, or twelve years, or even many more years, would think: "Whatever portion of food, fodder, grain, or drink falls to my share, I shall divide half of it between my father and mother, and give the other half to the

monks, and I will never abandon the gift of offerings to the monks." O son of good family, how much would such a hero's portion amount to in such evil times? In a half-month there would be one single meal. And even that single meal he would give to the monks, and so would become one whose merit is inexhaustible.

Having given in such a way, in this world
he becomes a man of excellence, desired by those who seek the good.
What purpose does heedlessness serve here for oneself?
Therefore, giving heed to the teaching is the highest thing.

Wealth is depleted by enemies, by thieves and many such,
by kings, by water and fire, by friends and companions,
by kinsmen who are not dear, by those who consume one's share,
and by one's own performance of evil.

But one's own wealth that a person actually makes use of
for themselves and their own enjoyment —
that wealth, even when spent and even when harmed by others,
is not exhausted, for the sake of the holy Dharma.

What is consumed here is the best; what lies beyond is never exhausted.
In this world it grows; in the world beyond
it is not exhausted — it makes one's form and complexion excellent.
When seen, all rejoice; one gains acquisition,
and complexion and renown shine forth brilliantly.
One's livestock will not be exhausted,
one's male and female servants will continue working,
and the boundaries of one's work will not decline.
For such a person there is no quarrel with a neighbor, and no fighting;
that one forever attains the highest freedom from harmful intent.
A person delighting in giving, in this world,
will obtain these and other such qualities.

Therefore one who always desires the Dharma —
will meet with the buddhas.

One who releases body and life freely without clinging —
that best of human beings is truly the one who is openhanded.
With affectionate compassion for all sentient beings,
seeing them as one's own children, one is endearing and possessed of
learning.

Meditative concentration, vigilance, and hearing are immeasurable. One who is wise and dwells in the household must always act in that way — and for all of these, such examples are many.

Now, what are those laywomen (upāsikā) of that time like? From the moment the crow calls at dawn, each one takes up her broom herself, sweeps around her own household, and plasters the ground with a paste of fine, fragrant mud, making it a beautiful adornment to the earth — such is the good conduct she performs. When she knows that many almsmen are coming there, with her own hands she consistently and well provides excellent food and drink; and may I meet and associate with them in my own village, town, or hamlets. May I never be born on the outskirts of a distant land, and may I never make seasonal festivals with a spiritual friend only once every four seasons. May I always practice generosity, moral discipline, and listening, and always engage in the discourse of the Dharma. Such is this sister, a laywoman of perfect and splendid qualities, whose mind is utterly pure. These, then, are the qualities of a laywoman.

Now, what are those monks (bhikṣu) and nuns (bhikṣuṇī) like? They are tamed, peaceful, and free from shamelessness; their defilements are exhausted; they bear their final body; and they are a retinue resembling the heartwood of sandalwood.

Now, what are those great bodhisattvas, the great beings, like? All of them desire the Dharma of the Tathāgata. All of them hold the sūtras of the tathāgatagarbha. All of them teach the benefit of the tathāgatagarbha. All of them desire the permanence of the buddha. All of them are skilled in the language of intended meaning. All of them teach sūtras of definitive meaning. They are tolerant. All of them are supremely devoted to those who have entered into the practice of cutting off and benefiting those of broken moral discipline. They have attained great faith in the Great Vehicle. They do not regard the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas with wonder. They are wise in not teaching other sūtras while setting aside the supreme and vast sūtras such as this one. They proclaim and do not abandon the teaching that wherever the buddha is permanent, there is the tathāgatagarbha. They are steadfast. They are empty of the view of the perishable composite — not in the sense of emptiness as such, but in that all conditioned things are empty of inherent nature. They seek that most excellent and ultimate ground. Such are

they, relying on qualities such as these. The remaining qualities are inconceivable.

Therefore, Kāśyapa, you should circumambulate this assembly two or three times. Then the elder, the great Kāśyapa, looked and examined the remaining assembly two or three times, and upon dismissal there remained those persons who were like husks. And upon his dismissing them by that third round of dismissal, there remained only those who were not like husks at all.

Then the Blessed One again declared to the elder, the great Kāśyapa: Kāśyapa, this assembly has now become pure — it has become the essence. The Blessed One further declared: Kāśyapa, this assembly has been well refined. Excellent! Excellent! The question was asked: Blessed One, how has the assembly been completely refined? It is like the autumn moon on the fifteenth day in its purity. Kāśyapa, it is like this — for example, as an accountant or an accountant's student —

— whatever remains of the provisions set aside for those bound by their former vows, just as it was recorded, and all those who have come into the assembly — from "all of these" as far as "immeasurable and incalculable" — the rest is as before. Kāśyapa, those who constitute a fraction of a hundredth of a thousandth of a ten-millionth part of all of those: they are the sublime human beings, the assembly of the fearless ones sitting here. And so, Kāśyapa, now you are to ask the assembly: Friends, are you able to hear this great, vast, one-vehicle sūtra of the Great Vehicle called the Great Drum, which is difficult to have faith in and difficult to believe? Kāśyapa, in that same way, ask the assembly a second and even a third time.

The Blessed One replied: Excellent! And thereupon the elder, the great Kāśyapa, rose from his seat, arranged his outer robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, bowed his head to the feet of the Blessed One, rose, and having circumambulated three times, he spoke to that great assembly: Wise ones, are you worthy to hear this great sūtra called the Great Drum? This singular Great Vehicle of the Tathāgata — this Great Vehicle that lies beyond the domain of all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas — will be taught to you.

Thus the great elder Kāśyapa urged them a second and even a third time, and they replied: Venerable Kāśyapa, we have come here for the sake of hearing the sacred Dharma, and we wish to hear it. Venerable Kāśyapa, may the Tathāgata, out of loving care for us, be pleased to proclaim this great sūtra

well.

The great Kāśyapa replied: How shall you have faith in it?

They replied: Venerable Kāśyapa, consider this example — a man who, having fathered a child at the age of twenty, is told that he has sons who are a hundred years old. If the Tathāgata himself declares it to be just so, we will believe it likewise. How much more, then, venerable Kāśyapa, shall we desire to hear the sacred Dharma? For the Tathāgata does as he says; the Tathāgata perceives all; the Tathāgata sees with the eye of a buddha. Venerable Kāśyapa, furthermore, we are known to the Tathāgata.

He replied: Wise ones, you are worthy to hear this great sūtra of the Great Drum, to read it, to hold it, and to teach it.

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, just as a father who fathered a child at twenty has sons who are a hundred years old, so too is this sūtra of the Great Drum. Why is that? Because it is said that the Tathāgata, even while passing fully into nirvāṇa, still continues to abide, and because in what are not a self and not a self's own, the word "self" is nonetheless used.

They said: That is known to the Blessed One alone; whatever the Blessed One has said, we will hold it to be just so.

Kāśyapa said: Blessed One, may the Tathāgata now expound this great sūtra of the Great Drum. Blessed One, may the Tathāgata beat the drum of the Dharma. Blessed One, may the Tathāgata sound the conch of the Dharma.

The Blessed One declared: Excellent! Excellent, Kāśyapa! Now, Kāśyapa, hear this great sūtra of the Great Drum.

They replied: Blessed One, we will hear it. And why is that?

Blessed One, even though this lies beyond my own domain of experience, the Tathāgata has shown me this honor for the sake of the great sūtra of the Great Drum, and that is why.

They asked further: How is that? And Kāśyapa said: The Blessed One spoke these words to me: "Kāśyapa, sit here together with me; come closer." Blessed One, I feel that this was done on my behalf and for that purpose, and I am grateful for it.

The Blessed One declared: Excellent! Excellent, Kāśyapa! It was indeed said by me for this very purpose. Kāśyapa, consider the following example: King Prasenajit of Kosala puts his elephants, horses, and soldiers through training

with food, drink, fodder, and the like. Why is that? Because when the time comes that the great drum, the clay drums, and the conch shells sound forth their tremendous noise, and when banners, victory standards, and flags are raised, and when a great host of enemy troops is drawing near — at that moment, recalling the benefit of the training they have received, the soldiers will engage the enemy force in battle. The king thinks: "At that moment they will also be of benefit to the sentient beings, and they will also be of benefit to my commands." And indeed it turns out just so.

Kāśyapa, in exactly the same way, after I have passed into complete nirvāṇa, you will bring forth this great sūtra of the Great Drum. It is for this reason that I have offered you half my seat — know it to be certain, and act accordingly.

Kāśyapa said: Blessed One, it is fitting that I be established as the eldest among the sons born from your mind.

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, consider this example: King Prasenajit of Kosala trains his own sons in various treatises and practical arts so that in the future they may perpetuate his royal lineage. In the same way, Kāśyapa, after I have passed on, you will bring forth this sūtra.

Kāśyapa, consider further: King Prasenajit of Kosala, upon being acclaimed by many kings, goes out to do battle with them all. Of the soldiers of that occasion — the mahouts, the cavalry, and the lesser infantry — those who, though well-armored, hear the sound of the great drum and the conch and are not startled, not frightened, and do not turn back: to these the king gives provisions, lodging, food, drink, clothing, ornaments, garments, and equipment. Those soldiers who are different from these, but who have nonetheless entered the battlefield and engaged in combat: to these the king gives gold, jewels, pearls, and the like, as well as towns and districts. And those among them who are heroes, who do not retreat even with their units, who are accompanied by elephants, cavalry, and charioteers and who defeat the enemy host: these the king himself singled out and invests with the crown of a viceroy.

Kāśyapa, in exactly the same way, among my śrāvakas — the monks, the nuns, the laymen, and the laywomen — those who have trained well in the precepts exactly as they were well established, who are restrained by the vow of individual liberation (prātimokṣa), who abide in the Vinaya's conduct and its domain: to these the Tathāgata gives the happiness of gods and humans. Those who, beyond this, defeat the māra of the aggregates (skandhamāra),

the māra of the afflictions (kleśamāra), the māra of the lord of death, and the māra of the divine son: to these the Tathāgata binds the crown of liberation through the Four Noble Truths. And those others who, with the vastest aspiration, are devoted to the greatness of the essence of the Tathāgata — the great self that is permanent, stable, peaceful,

and eternal — those sentient beings who desire this: to them the Tathāgata binds the crown of the Great Vehicle empowerment (abhiṣeka), endowed with the supreme of all aspects, the primordial wisdom of omniscience.

Kāśyapa, in just this way you too, today, have been bound with the crown of the Great Vehicle empowerment, and before many hundreds of thousands of buddhas you shall bring forth this great sūtra of the Great Drum. Therefore, Kāśyapa, it is fitting that you too, now that I have passed beyond, should cause this sūtra to arise.

Then Kāśyapa made this request: Blessed One, although for the moment I cannot see clearly with my own discernment, yet whether the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, has fully passed into nirvāṇa or whether he remains, I shall bring it forth and teach it.

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, excellent! Now the Tathāgata begins to expound the great sūtra called the Great Drum.

Then from the sky, hosts of gods and hosts of dragons offered their approval, saying: Excellent! Kāśyapa, excellent, excellent! For the benefit and happiness of all sentient beings, now the hosts of gods and the hosts of dragons also release a rain of flowers and pour down a great continuous rain of fragrant powder filled with nectar-water. Kāśyapa, you are born from the face and heart of the Blessed One, and you are worthy to be the eldest son of the Tathāgata.

Then the hosts of gods and the hosts of dragons, speaking in unison, uttered these verses:

In the cities of Śrāvastī, when the great drum and the very great conch resound,

the Protector, the Lord of Dharma, in the Jeta Grove, causes the great drum of Dharma to resound.

Kāśyapa, you too: beat the drum of Dharma!

The sūtra spoken by the kings of Dharma —

if you strike the great drum of Dharma with the mallet of inquiry,

the God above the gods will resolve the many doubts about the Dharma.

This concludes the chapter called "The Coming of Kāśyapa" from the Great Sūtra of the Great Drum.

Then the Blessed One addressed the elder, the great Kāśyapa, with these words: Kāśyapa, earlier in this sūtra I spoke again and again of a certain monk named Yāśa of Faithful Mind. Whatever monk or nun, layman or laywoman, or sentient beings who have heard that monk's name — all of them will have the thorns of attachment, aversion, and delusion extracted. Why is that? Kāśyapa, consider this example: Prasenajit, the king of Kośala, had a physician's son named Excellent Medicine. On an occasion when King Prasenajit was to engage in battle with an enemy army, as the king was preparing for war he summoned the physician Excellent Medicine and said: O physician, prepare without delay a medicine of such a kind that, for whatever sentient beings are pierced by thorns, it will extract those thorns as they require, and bring it quickly. Then the physician Excellent Medicine took the king of medicines called Poisonous-Medicine-Crusher, and smeared it upon, fumigated it into, and beat upon the great drum that was to go before the great king into battle. The moment it was smeared and fumigated and beaten, whatever sentient beings had been pierced by thorns — hearing that sound at a distance of one or two leagues, by that mere hearing alone, all the thorns of each and every one of those sentient beings were extracted; the thorns were removed. Kāśyapa, in just the same way, whatever sentient beings have heard the name of the monk Yāśa of Faithful Mind — all of them will have the thorns of attachment, aversion, and delusion extracted. Why is that? Because he has brought forth and extensively propagated this sūtra within my teaching,

Such is the power of having manifested the Dharma directly. Kāśyapa, consider this: even that great royal drum, an insentient, ordinary thing — when smeared and fumigated and beaten by one who is sentient, it immediately brings benefit to sentient beings. How much more needless is it to speak of hearing the name of the great bodhisattva of Vast and Faithful Mind, by which the three afflictions of sentient beings are severed? If simply hearing the name of a bodhisattva causes the thorns of attachment, aversion, and delusion to be extracted from sentient beings, then how much more needless is it to speak of reciting "Homage to the Blessed One Śākyamuni" or of proclaiming in full the qualities of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones? And if simply hearing the name of the Blessed One Śākyamuni causes the thorns of attachment, aversion, and delusion to be extracted from sentient beings, then how much more needless is it to speak of a compassionate teacher who, for

the benefit of beings, extracts a passage from this Great Sūtra of the Great Drum, or teaches a verse, or a few words, or even just a title, or expounds a chapter — so that the thorns of attachment, aversion, and delusion are extracted from all those sentient beings? Why is that? Because I have declared, "Monks, the aspirations of one endowed with moral discipline will be fulfilled," for the reason that such aspirations were thoroughly cultivated before. This is the nature of reality of all the buddhas, the Blessed Ones — that is to say, it is something that was not made, did not arise, and will not cease through this Great Sūtra of the Great Drum. Kāśyapa, therefore, in a future time you too will become like me. Why is that? Because whatever monk, or nun, or layman, or laywoman hears even your name — the thorns of attachment, aversion, and delusion of all those sentient beings will be extracted. Therefore, Kāśyapa, you too will have requested this sūtra and will bring it forth in the world for a long time.

Kāśyapa spoke: Blessed One, if it is so, please be so kind as to well explain to me some portion of this Great Sūtra of the Great Drum.

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, the time has come; do you request of me some portion. Kāśyapa said, "Excellent!" and put forth this request.

Blessed One,

Where existence is, there is suffering;

Where there is no existence, there is no suffering —

That nirvāṇa is supremely blissful.

To abandon both pleasure and pain,

Supreme nirvāṇa comes to be.

Where there is existence, there is both pleasure and suffering;

Where there is no existence, there is neither pleasure nor suffering.

Therefore, one who wishes to attain nirvāṇa —

A noble son should cut off entirely the wish for existence.

Please, what is the meaning of this teaching?

Then, in response, the Blessed One spoke well in verse:

All that is craved is impermanent and unstable,

And throughout it all there is no essence;

Whatever is existence is suffering,

And wherever there is no existence there is no suffering.

If there is no existence, there is no suffering;

Since here where there is existence suffering arises,

One should not take delight in existence,
And one should not place one's trust in things that exist.

Blessed One, you teach
That existence and non-existence,
And the arising of pleasure and pain, both obtain.

Having spoken thus, the Blessed One addressed the elder Kāśyapa the Great with these words: Kāśyapa, the meaning of these words is the meaning of stable, settled speech, and for the time being, Kāśyapa, you do not understand it. Sentient beings for the most part do not cut off existence,

Sentient beings are threaded through by the cord of formations;
Yet without existence, nirvāṇa is supreme bliss.

Kāśyapa asked: One who attains nirvāṇa —
That nirvāṇa does not abide;
In it, bliss is but a name,
And no person will ever experience it.

The Blessed One declared: Liberation is not merely a name;
Existence, non-existence — what is the ground of what is permanent?
Therefore this is not the domain nor the sphere of activity of all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, how can it be both form and permanent?

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, consider this: a person comes from a southern land called Ruined and Destroyed, and someone asks that person, "From where have you come here?" That person replies, "I have come from the southern land of Ruined and Destroyed." The other person then asks, "In which direction does that land lie?" The person then points with a finger toward the sky in the direction of the southern road. Kāśyapa, would that other person trust that person? And why? Because if one were to go, one would see it. Kāśyapa, in just the same way, though you have not seen it, you should trust with faith.

The Noble Chapter of the Great Drum — the Second Fascicle.

Then the Blessed One proclaimed these verses:

Just as one shows the sky by pointing a finger,
So nirvāṇa is taught by name alone.

Just as the man from the southern land of Ruined and Destroyed,
So I myself arrived without any fixed support.

Kāśyapa, if one sees the meaning in this as well,
There is no question of cause being necessary or unnecessary;
For a meaning that has not become directly perceived,
Cause and condition are likewise the same.

Kāśyapa, therefore, the buddha, the Blessed One, through many causes,
makes clear the meaning of the word liberation.

The Blessed One asked: Kāśyapa, what do you consider a cause to be?

Kāśyapa replied: A cause, I would say, is that which effects.

The Blessed One declared: What word serves as the synonym for condition?

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, what is called a condition — that is support.

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, through a logical example, through cause, through application and connecting, and through the effecting factors, make clear precisely how it truly is, just as it is.

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, take the example that from the union of father and mother a child is born. In that case, the mother is the cause, and the father is the condition. Therefore, both father and mother are the cause and condition of the child. In just the same way, through cause and condition, phenomena arise — this is what is called "established." And what is "established"? What is called "established" is worldly convention. And what is "world"?

Kāśyapa replied: It is whatever is designated through the possession of sentient beings. And what is a sentient being? What is called a sentient being is designated as a name for phenomena. And what are phenomena?

Kāśyapa replied: There are phenomena that are not Dharma, and there are phenomena of Dharma. And those phenomena too are shown in two aspects. What are the two aspects? Conditioned and unconditioned, and form and formless — beyond those two there is no third. And what are phenomena like?

Kāśyapa replied: What are called phenomena — these are without form.

The Blessed One declared: And what is that which is not a phenomenon like?

Kāśyapa replied: What is called "not a phenomenon" — that too is without form.

The Blessed One declared: If both phenomena and that which is not a phenomenon are without form and without marks, then which is the phenomenon and which is the non-phenomenon?

Kāśyapa replied: What is called "phenomenon" — that is what is called nirvāṇa. What is called "not a phenomenon" — that is what is called craving.

The Blessed One declared:

If both phenomena and that which is not a phenomenon are without form and without marks, then by what mark, in what manner, and through what sign do the buddhas discern: "This is a phenomenon"?

Kāśyapa replied: Sentient beings, born in cyclic existence, rely upon merit and virtue and upon the various roots of virtue, and through directly and rightly practicing the Dharma in that manner and in that way, all the marks of virtue come to arise fully. Those sentient beings who practice the Dharma directly and rightly in that way — those are what is called "phenomena." Sentient beings, born in cyclic existence, who lack merit, who engage in all manner of sinful actions, who practice all that is contrary to the Dharma — in those very ones all the marks of sin and non-virtue come to arise fully. Those sentient beings who practice what is contrary to the Dharma in that way — those are what is called "not a phenomenon." Now, what is called "a sentient being" comprises the inner earth element, the water element, the fire element, and the wind element — gathered together and designated by these four elements — along with the six sense sources of eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind, the five sense faculties, feeling, perception, volition, mind, and mental consciousness. Thus, all that up to and including the thirteen limbs of existence is called "all phenomena."

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, if it is only in relation to those that one speaks of the phenomena of sentient beings, then what are the phenomena belonging to that which is called "sentient being"?

Kāśyapa replied: In that which is designated "sentient being," there is not a single phenomenon that belongs to it.

And why is that? Blessed One, consider, for example, that which is called the great drum of Prasenajit (Prasena-jit), king of Kosala — what exactly is that called the great drum?

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, whatever the great drum is, that very thing is to be understood as the great drum. What is called the great drum — it is the collection of these three things: leather, a striker, and a wooden frame. Those phenomena that constitute this collection are called the great drum.

Kāśyapa replied: Then is it the person who beats it that is called the great drum?

The Blessed One declared: Even without a person, when a great drum is moved by the wind, sound arises.

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, what then? Is the great drum a phenomenon, or is it not a phenomenon?

The Blessed One declared: This that is called a great drum is neither a phenomenon nor a non-phenomenon.

Kāśyapa replied: Then what is it called?

The Blessed One declared: A phenomenon that is not associated with any other phenomenon, and that is also not a non-phenomenon — this is called a phenomenon that is not categorized.

Kāśyapa replied: If there exists such a thing as a phenomenon that is not categorized, then there would be three kinds of phenomena in the world.

The Blessed One declared: What is called "not categorized" is like what is neither male nor female — it is called a neuter. How is that to be illustrated?

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, suppose you say: "This is a child born of a father and a mother." If a father and a mother were to have no offspring, then some might say: "Father and mother are not cause and condition." Furthermore, those sentient beings who have no seed-essence — because they have no fruit, they are forever to be known as neuter. And why is that? Kāśyapa, consider the king of Kosala, Prasenajit: when he was gravely afflicted in the company of an enemy army, in a condition of utter humiliation — those who lived under his authority and power yet neither followed him nor came to his rescue at that time are to be regarded as women.

Kāśyapa replied: Why is that?

The Blessed One declared:

Kings examine and assess the character of those who live by their patronage, and then put them to work. For this reason, those sentient beings who have no seed-essence cannot become father or mother, and so those sentient beings

are forever to be regarded as neuter.

The Blessed One then declared: There are virtuous phenomena, non-virtuous phenomena, and indeterminate phenomena. Virtuous phenomena are pleasant feeling. Non-virtuous phenomena are painful feeling. Indeterminate phenomena are that which is neither pleasant feeling nor painful feeling. Sentient beings are forever in contact with these three kinds of phenomena. Now, what is called pleasant feeling is the five desirable qualities enjoyed by gods and humans. What is called painful feeling belongs to hell-beings, to those born in the animal realm, and to the world of hungry ghosts. What is neither pleasant nor painful feeling is like a fine rash or an itch — and in the case of a fine rash and an itch, are sentient beings afflicted by afflictions thereby indeterminate?

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, that is not so.

The Blessed One declared: Why not?

Kāśyapa replied: Because suffering arises from pleasure, and suffering also arises from suffering — both of these, therefore, are indeterminate.

The Blessed One declared: Does disease arise from food?

Kāśyapa replied: At the time when one desires it, it is called pleasant. At the time when one falls ill from it, it is called painful. And whatever an itch may be, that is what is called indeterminate.

The Blessed One declared: If that is so, then pleasant and painful would also be called indeterminate, and father, mother, and child would also become indeterminate.

Kāśyapa replied: That is not so, Blessed One.

The Blessed One declared: Well then, how is it?

Kāśyapa replied: Just as the gods of neither-perception-nor-non-perception and so forth are not said to be a basis for establishing being, so too this virtuous phenomenon is similar to that.

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, you have said that feeling and perception constitute a sentient being. In that case, those gods of neither-perception-nor-non-perception and so forth would not be sentient beings.

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, those too possess the character of formations.

The Blessed One declared: Well then, are these phenomena apart from feeling and perception to be called sentient beings — or is it that some would say there exist sentient beings of that kind? In that case, those endowed with phenomena that are not those of a sentient being would become sentient beings. Why? Is a sentient being possessed of form, or is it not possessed of form?

Kāśyapa replied: It is neither possessed of form nor not possessed of form, and yet those endowed with such phenomena are called sentient beings.

The Blessed One declared: If that is so, then those endowed with phenomena that are not those of a sentient being, who are to be born as sentient beings, shall be called formless. If that is the case, then in this world there would arise two kinds of phenomena: those with form and those without form — phenomena possessed of form and phenomena not possessed of form. Is liberation together with phenomena, or is it together with what is not a phenomenon? Is there liberation even for the formless gods?

Kāśyapa replied: Is there liberation even for gods who have no form?

The Blessed One declared: That is not so. Because there exist conditioned and unconditioned phenomena, those formless gods are also to be counted among conditioned things, whereas liberation is unconditioned.

Kāśyapa replied: In that case, even the formless gods would come to be possessed of form.

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, speak clearly — explain how all conditioned things are possessed of form, and how unconditioned things are not possessed of form.

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, if one were to say that the formless gods are possessed of form, then such form would have to fall within the domain of a buddha.

"It would not fall within our domain." The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, excellent, excellent! In just the same way, the buddhas, Blessed Ones, who have gone to liberation, are also within my domain — they too are possessed of form, and liberation itself is also possessed of form."

He then declared further: "Kāśyapa, do you correctly know the divine abode and the activities of the formless gods?"

He declared again: "Kāśyapa, would you count the gods of the form realm among those called 'formless'? Why then do you say that they do not fall within our domain?"

He declared further: "Look clearly and correctly in just the same way upon the buddhas of supremely purified mind who have attained liberation — look upon them too as being possessed of form."

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, if that is so, then since those who have attained liberation continue to abide, they would still come to experience pleasure and suffering.

The Blessed One declared: "If a sick sentient being were to take a medicinal extract and drink it, and thereby become free of illness, would that being then still have offspring born sick? If there were some residue remaining, it would necessarily be so."

The Blessed One declared: "Would it be so even without karma?"

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, that would not be so.

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, the very abandonment of pleasure and suffering is liberation. Illness is like pleasure and suffering, and the attainment of nirvāṇa is to be understood as unlike illness."

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, what then? Is the exhaustion of illness attained because there is no karma in what is called the abandonment of pleasure and suffering?

The Blessed One declared: "The attainment of liberation is the separation from — and the exhaustion, as it were, of — whatever karma pertains to worldly pleasure and suffering."

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, then why does it not perish?

The Blessed One declared: "It is said to be like space — space like space — and the great ocean is said to be like space. Is the incomparable space like the great ocean? In just the same way, liberation is without compare. Just as the formless gods, though possessed of form, do not know that they abide in such and such a state of joy, so too the liberation of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas is without designation."

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, space too is impermanent.

The Blessed One declared: "Consider, for example, how it is when a palace white as a swan has been built for the king Prasenajit — the space that

deteriorates there is called a deterioration of space. "

Kāśyapa replied: How then does a formless phenomenon perish? And how do the formless gods perish?

The Blessed One declared: "Would you count those formless gods as sentient beings?"

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, how could space, which has no mind, come to have a mind?

The Blessed One declared: "Just as space does not perish for a house or mountain that rests upon space, so too the dhātu of nirvāṇa, pervading all beings, is similar to that. Does the agent and the experiencer resemble space, which does not perish, in the way that the support does?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, at the time of nirvāṇa, whatever karmic and afflictive phenomena (Skt. kleśa) belonging to sentient beings exist — those will perish."

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, how is it when all sentient beings and all phenomena are absent? It is like the dissolution of a great drum.

Kāśyapa then asked further: "Just as from the two lights — the light of a parasol and the light of a jewel — one says they have entered into the world, and just as among humans one speaks of something as 'mine,' Blessed One, what is the karmic maturation of this single phenomenon?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, do you not know?"

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, I request you to explain.

The Blessed One declared: "Speak of the arising of the moon."

Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, the moon is not a phenomenon arising from the karmic maturation of sentient beings.

The Blessed One declared: "If that is so, then an example must be given."

"But if the jewel, the moon, the sun, and fire were not made by sentient beings but came into being through an assembly of conditions, are not those sun and moon, which even the gods above bow down to, themselves sentient beings? Blessed One, a buddha, the Blessed One, is also called a sentient being right up until the moment of passing into nirvāṇa, and so they too should be counted among the number of sentient beings."

The Blessed One declared: "That is not a sentient being."

"For what reason, Blessed One?"

"An extraordinary spiritual friend of a village — one who is uncommon — is not reckoned on a par with ordinary sentient beings. A buddha is the harmonious cause of phenomena born of karmic maturation, and a buddha has passed into complete nirvāṇa; and sentient beings, too, are the harmonious cause of phenomena born of karmic maturation."

"Kāśyapa, at the time when all sentient beings have been exhausted, tell me: if fire were then to arise and destroy, or were about to arise and destroy, what would you say of that?"

"Blessed One, I do not know. You yourself said earlier that I do not understand."

"Blessed One, birth, aging, sickness, and death — from where do they come, and where do they go?"

The Blessed One declared: "The sound of a great drum — from where does it come, and where does it go?"

"Blessed One, it comes from the assembly of conditions."

"How so?"

"Just as all phenomena are unmade and have no maker and are free from a maker, so too the sound of the great drum is like that."

"That is not correct. Does a great drum have a maker?"

"Blessed One, it does not."

"In the same way, those sentient beings who have attained the irreversible ground of nirvāṇa — who makes them? There is no maker. Sentient beings act upon themselves by their own nature. How so? If a sentient being performs merit, that one becomes a buddha; but if one does not perform it, one remains a sentient being."

"Blessed One, who first made sentient beings?"

The Blessed One declared: "And who made the formless gods such as the gods of neither-perception-nor-non-perception (Skt. *naivasaṃjñānāsaṃjñāyatana*) and so forth? And how do they remain alive?"

"Blessed One, if they remain through karma, then understanding their karma and likewise seeking to understand the manner of the householder and

merchant would offer no foothold for such inquiry. Who causes the very stable abiding?"

Kāśyapa replied: "Karma does."

"From karma many phenomena arise, and from virtuous karma also many phenomena arise. So what are the phenomena that arise from virtue, and what are those that arise from non-virtue?"

The Blessed One declared: "From karma, continued existence arises. From virtuous karma, liberation arises."

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, how can liberation arise from virtue when liberation is an unborn state?"

The Blessed One declared: "From suchness, which is not other."

"If a buddha arises from virtue, how is the unborn state attained?"

The Blessed One declared: "Through perfectly cultivated action."

"And who trained in that?"

The Blessed One declared: "The buddhas of beginningless time trained in it."

"Who throughout all of beginningless time gave rise to it through emanation and trained in it?"

The Blessed One declared: "This cannot be known or contemplated by all the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Even if a person of great learning, like Śāriputra, were to appear in the world, and were to contemplate without cease for a vast and boundless length of time in this way — asking what is the very first arising of a buddha among buddhas — they would not be able to know or contemplate it; before they could do so, they would pass into nirvāṇa."

The Blessed One then declared further: "Even beings like the great Maudgalyāyana, traveling continuously by the power of their miraculous ability into the endless reaches of the future, would still be unable to comprehend the arising of a buddha among buddhas or to perceive his pure lands."

The same is true even of bodhisattvas such as Maitreya and the rest who have attained the tenth ground. The same is true of all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas alike.

The Blessed One then declared further: "Just as it is with the arising of a buddha, so too you should understand that the arising of sentient beings is exactly the same."

"Blessed One, does that not mean there must be an agent and an experiencer?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, the agent and the experiencer are the cause."

"Blessed One, does this world ever come to an end, or does it not?"

The Blessed One declared: "The world never comes to an end — not at any time, not in any way, not even once."

The Blessed One then declared: "Kāśyapa, let me offer you a simile."

"Blessed One, what is it like?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, consider this: if someone were to dip the tip of a single hair into an inexhaustible ocean, would even the amount equal to a single cattle-hoofprint be drawn up, or would it not?"

"Blessed One, it would indeed."

The Blessed One then declared: "Kāśyapa, in a past time, after an inconceivably great number of countless aeons had passed — an aeon vast beyond all vastness — there appeared in the world a perfectly and fully awakened buddha named Rāhu. At that time, as that Blessed One was teaching the Dharma in this very great city, a young Licchavi named Priyadarśana, Pleasing to All the World, became a righteous Dharma-king, a wheel-turning sovereign. That king then went into the presence of the Tathāgata, and having offered great wealth and a retinue of nāgas, he made offerings to the Blessed One together with his queen and spoke these words: 'Blessed One, when shall I become a bodhisattva?'

At that time the Blessed One declared: 'Great King, whoever has become a wheel-turning sovereign will become none other than a bodhisattva. Why is that? Because for Indra (Śakra) and Brahmā there is no such thing as being a wheel-turning king — and so one becomes none other than a bodhisattva. Great King, whoever has become a layman will in turn become Indra and Brahmā. Having been Indra himself and Brahmā himself many many times over, after that you will become a righteous Dharma-king and a wheel-turning sovereign. You yourself will have been Indra and Brahmā as many times as there are grains of sand along the river Gaṅgā, and only after that will you attain this very status of wheel-turning sovereignty.'

Then again that king asked the Blessed One: 'Blessed One, what are Indra and Brahmā like?'

At that time that Blessed One declared: 'All those Indras, Brahmās, and the like who are comparable to you — those who wear a crown — are in no way more beautiful in your presence. It is just as all the śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas are not brilliant, not resplendent, not radiant before the body of a buddha. In the same way, Great King, you today, if you were to fully internalize what is comparable to the complexion of a buddha's body — Kāśyapa, why even speak of drawing a comparison between you as a wheel-turning sovereign and Brahmā, lord of the world Sahā, or Śakra Kauśika? Kāśyapa, then that wheel-turning sovereign, lord of the four continents, asked the Blessed One again: 'Blessed One, what of this — shall I become a buddha in the world?'

At that time the awakened and Blessed One declared: 'Son of good family, even after a long time —

you will attain buddhahood after a very long time. And why is that? Great King, if you were to abandon your own merit, cast it entirely aside, and take on an ordinary person's perception, then — at that very time — if you were to scoop up this great ocean with the tip of a hair and reduce it to no more than the size of a cow's hoofprint, there would then arise in the world a fully and perfectly awakened buddha named Dīpaṃkara, and in that same era there would arise a king named Sādhipatī. At that time the Blessed One Dīpaṃkara would prophesy: 'Great King, you — in a future age — will be called Gautama, supreme among the Śākyas.' And in that age there would occur an eon of conflagration. If from this very moment onward you were to reduce the great ocean to no more than the size of a cow's hoofprint, then after many hundreds of years, many hundreds of intermediate eons, and many thousands of eons had passed, there would occur many eons of conflagration, and buddhas would arise; by pleasing and worshipping those buddhas, Great King, you would reduce the great ocean to the size of a cow's hoofprint.

As for how that wheel-turning sovereign Kāśyapa would continually drain that great ocean with the tip of a hair — in this way: whenever Śakra (Indra), or Brahmā, or a wheel-turning sovereign himself experienced great bliss and wished to experience it again and again, that great ocean would be drained by this gradual process. Then, after those eons of conflagration had run their course, and after those blessed buddhas had passed fully into nirvāṇa, there

would at times — perhaps once in a hundred — arise a buddha-teacher named Dīpaṃkara, and the Blessed One Dīpaṃkara would prophesy to that king Sādhīpatī: 'Great King, you will become a buddha.' At that time, Great King, you — having become the eldest young son of that king — would together with him receive a prophecy of buddhahood.

Then the Tathāgata would utter this solemn declaration: 'Great King, your son, having drained the great ocean in just that way and being now your son, is not a king of ordinary nature. He is either Brahmā, lord of the world Sahā, or Śakra, king of the gods, or a righteous wheel-turning sovereign, a king of Dharma endowed with Dharma.' The Tathāgata would then also utter this solemn declaration, taking it as an illustration: 'Sādhīpatī, such is the difficulty of attaining awakening — your son will become one of great diligence.' This illustration was taken up to show the point: 'Sādhīpatī, your son here, having abandoned sixty thousand women adorned with jewels and garlands of earrings, women beautiful as divine maidens, like spittle reduced to ash — having heard the proclamation, "Alas, desires are impermanent!" — perceiving those women beautiful as divine maidens as like spittle reduced to ash, and having heard the proclamation, "Alas, desires are neither lasting, nor stable, nor permanent!" — thinking, "It is easy for me to go forth from home into homelessness" — he will go forth in just that way.'

Thus the Tathāgata, at the time when in this world-realm of Sahā the Protector named Śākyamuni would appear, would declare to that young man: 'Great King, you will be a young Licchavi named Priyadarśana — Pleasing to Behold by All the World.' Then, in that world-realm, at the time when the Protector had passed fully into nirvāṇa and the teaching was in decline, at the age of eighty, having become a monk named Sudhara —

he would have no regard even for his own life, and would bring forth this sūtra. Then, after a hundred years had passed, he would die and be reborn in the world-realm of Bliss (Sukhāvatī). At that time you will manifest many great miraculous powers, dwelling on the eighth ground. One body will remain in Sukhāvatī, while an emanation body will be placed in Tuṣita, and will inquire of the Protector Ajita concerning this sūtra — so ran the prophecy.

Then King Powerful Lord of the Earth, having heard the prophecy about his son, was thoroughly satisfied in all his faculties, thinking: "My son has been given a prophecy of buddhahood." And that young man, for his part, became yet more steadfast in his earnest resolve.

Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, even the great ocean can be emptied if drawn out drop by drop, can it not?

The Blessed One replied: How so?

Kāśyapa said: Blessed One, consider this example: a certain brahmin who lives by begging counts out his kārṣāpaṇa coins and hides them in a pot, and then little by little gives coins out to his children as they need them. As they request, thinking, "These coins are running low," all of them are eventually spent. In just the same way, a great bodhisattva, if even one drop of water is drawn from the great ocean — examining it carefully — and in the same way fully examines all the remaining water, then, Blessed One, would not the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, fail to know the exhaustion of the mass of sentient beings? Need that even be said? Blessed One, the mass of sentient beings has no end, and all the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas together could not fathom it; yet the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, do know it.

The Blessed One declared: Excellent, excellent, Kāśyapa! That is indeed so: the mass of sentient beings has no end.

Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, do those sentient beings who have passed completely into nirvāṇa have an end, or do they not?

The Blessed One replied: Sentient beings have no end.

Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, what is meant by saying that sentient beings have no end?

The Blessed One declared: If there were an end, that would mean diminishment; and were there an increase, then the great purpose of this sūtra would be served. All of this should be understood in full through the collection of the three thousand verses previously spoken in this sūtra and properly designated. If those three thousand verses that are properly designated are not sufficient for understanding, then learn it well from what the monk of vast learning, who is possessed of a mind of faith, has asked — and from that alone.

The buddhas, the Blessed Ones — and all those who have passed completely into nirvāṇa — are permanent, stable, tranquil, and everlasting. For what reason, Blessed One, will those who have passed completely into nirvāṇa have no end?

The Blessed One declared: Just as a palace or a fine house may collapse and crumble from time to time, yet the sky remains unchanged — so too the

Protectors who have passed completely into nirvāṇa: each and every one of them is entirely and without exception liberated.

Consider also this: in the language of Sanskrit, the constituent sense of the word siddha is formed by means of the element ta, so that it comes to bear the inherent nature of the word meaning "accomplished" or "perfected." Just as in worldly treatises the completed word "accomplished" is rendered by such forms as nāmākhyāta, upasarga, siddham, dhita, and so forth — so that term "accomplished" is called siddha; and the accomplishment that is the meaning of that word "accomplished" is entirely without obscuration.

In the same way, when sentient beings have pacified what is called affliction — both above and below — and have attained liberation, there will be no arising again of the existence of birth, aging, and death.

Grammarians who read as they please take the word "siddha" — "accomplished" — and render it as "vidhū." They also condense words on their own authority and make them into the form of their own words. Why is this? It is because the tradition has reached its culmination and because students are to be brought to their culmination. And so, just as one learns the earlier letters and the various rites — whether pure or impure — without knowing them, and cuts and divides them, and then after learning the cutting and dividing calls them by the name "cutting and dividing" — in precisely the same way, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha likewise, from the moment of his anointing as a buddha at the awakening of perfect and complete enlightenment, remains uninterruptedly present in saṃsāra for as long as there are sentient beings, appearing to some as one who has arisen and to others demonstrating complete passing into nirvāṇa — and yet he does not deteriorate. Why is this? It is because, by reason of being an arhat, there will be no more arising of the existence of birth, aging, and death.

Kāśyapa, just as you understood above and below that the word "accomplished" does not become the form "unaccomplished" — in precisely the same way, know this of the blessed buddhas. The blessed buddhas become three buddhas in one body: through the single body of the Lord of the Śākyas they make all of these into buddhas themselves; and he who is called "the Undefeated, the Undefeated," who will become the Lord Maitreya (the bodhisattva of loving-kindness, the coming buddha), and I myself who am permanent — even the buddhas of the past are I, who am that very one — thus they are taught, each of them in their particulars. And however many of

the thousand buddhas of this aeon there may be, all of them are the buddha Śākyamuni. Know it to be thus.

The sphere of the word "buddha" is the sphere of the word of the skilled and realized one. It is said that the sphere of the word "buddha" and the sphere of the word "nirvāṇa" are of that very character. Just as the sphere of the word of the skilled and realized one does not deteriorate, so I the buddha too shall attain nirvāṇa that is a realized nirvāṇa.

Kāśyapa, if these sūtras of this kind are heard in future times, people will say: "These are fabrications." Why? Because the sphere of language is not evident in the speech of the buddha, and so the sūtra on the sphere of accomplished language was composed by someone. And because in the speech of the buddha the permanence of the Tathāgata is not evident, some have also fabricated it. And because in the speech of the buddha selflessness is not evident, some have also fabricated it. Again, because throughout all nine branches of the canonical scriptures the sūtra called "The Unequaled" is not to be found, some have fabricated it on their own. People say: "This sūtra of the Unequaled is nothing but a fabrication by certain individuals."

For example, when a king becomes endowed with generosity, many sealed jars full of accumulated treasure will arise from the earth. Why? Because in whatever measure jewels of every kind are distributed to the dead, the poor, the destitute, the beggars, and so forth — in just that measure, wondrous jewels of corresponding kinds will arise for him in the world.

In precisely the same way, a bodhisattva who is skilled in great skillful means, who teaches sentient beings whichever precious and profound Dharma teachings there may be, who knows contentment and who first renounces acquisitiveness in equipment and provisions — when one who has entered upon the teaching of the Dharma in this way proceeds in this manner, the following sūtras — which are the sūtras on abandoning things that are not noble — will be attained: emptiness, signlessness,

and wishlessness — such gateways as these will also be attained. Likewise, sūtras of this kind belonging to the chapter on the essence — those concerning the permanence of the Tathāgata and the existence of tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature) — will also be attained.

A question was posed: Blessed One, what is it like for a bodhisattva to show reverence for the Dharma?

The Blessed One declared: It is when one conducts oneself toward what is not fitting with a perception of its being fitting.

The question was put: How is that?

The Blessed One declared: Consider, for example, a time when there comes before Prasenajit, the king of Kosala, a messenger of another king — one born of low caste, a candāla, a pauper. Drums are beaten, many musical sounds arise, and a great proclamation is made from atop an elephant; a great seat is set out; and from the king he receives perfumes, garlands, unguents, flowers, powders, garments, and many ornaments. The king himself, having removed his fine garments, descends from his high throne, and though elephants, horses, and chariots are available, he goes on foot to receive him, and though seats and cushions are available, he sits on the bare ground before him. Why is this? It is because those of that world, though they have made him adorned with garments and ornaments, nevertheless honor him with the thought: "He is the king's messenger."

In just the same way, when a teacher of the Dharma is speaking, a monk or a layman should, at the time of the teaching, sit upon a low seat before me and conduct himself just as one would with divine powders, perfumes, garlands, unguents, incense, flowers, and ornaments. Whoever so conducts himself — for that one, these various wonders will arise in his presence, and yakṣas and kings of rākṣasas will also pay him homage, finding in him constant cause for astonishment.

For example, the food of the people of the northern continent of Uttarakuru (the continent of Unpleasant Sound) will increase and not diminish. Why is this? It is because for them, for as long as they live, there arises no perception of food and drink as something to be sought, and hunger, jealousy, and miserliness do not arise — and therefore there is no diminishment or interruption in between.

In just the same way, those in this Jambudvīpa — monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen — who inquire into, read, retain, and thoroughly master sūtras such as these, who teach them to others as well, and who, without interruption, do not become despondent, do not fall into doubt, do not vacillate with uncertainty, and do not give rise to disparagement: these persons will, through the constant blessing of the buddhas, find abundant food and drink in wondrous measure. Until they reach awakening, this will not be exhausted, not diminished, not wasted; there will be no interruption and no occasion of being

utterly pressed down in want.

Furthermore, for example, a monk who does not interrupt his practice and does not become negligent — the gods who dwell in the final body will pay him homage with their own bodies for as long as he lives. In just the same way, those in whom there will not arise even a sesame seed's worth of a perception of disparagement toward sūtras such as these — they are the very essence of the Tathāgata. They will attain permanence, the very permanence of the Tathāgata. Their teaching of these sūtras, their drawing near to them, their honoring and paying homage to them will also become manifest as the Tathāgatas themselves.

For example, wherever a wheel-turning king goes, the seven precious substances accompany him. In just the same way, wherever these teachings of benefit arise, sūtras such as these will also come to be present there. For example,

Wherever a wheel-turning king resides, the seven precious substances are present in that very place, while not even a single step away, in any other direction, are those precious things to be found — only lesser treasures exist there. In just the same way, whenever and wherever a teaching of benefit becomes manifest, sūtras such as these will come from the direction of the south, and having come, they will go to the presence of those beings; they will not remain in any other direction.

Here ends the third fascicle of the noble chapter of the Great Drum.

Now, other provisional sūtras accompanied by chapters on emptiness will also arise there, and if a Teacher is present in that place, they will remain in that very place. Furthermore, if a wheel-turning king departs in another direction, those sentient beings who have long served the king will think: "We too will go to whatever place the king has gone." In just the same way, wherever a teaching of benefit arises, sūtras such as these will arise there as well.

For example, when a wheel-turning king is about to appear, the seven precious substances will appear. In just the same way, when and wherever a teaching of benefit is about to arise, sūtras such as these will come into the hands of those very beings. Furthermore, when a wheel-turning king fails to find even one among the seven precious substances and searches for it, he will go to the very place where all seven precious substances are to be found. In just the same way, if one hears sūtras such as these and then searches in whatever place a teaching of benefit is present, it will be found there.

For example, in a place where a wheel-turning king is absent, there arise instead regional kings, wheel-turners of power, and assemblies of petty kings. In just the same way, in a place where sūtras such as these are not being expounded, teachers of benefit will teach and expound other, more ordinary sūtras accompanied by chapters on emptiness. Then, when those sentient beings see and hear many such sūtras and are taught by those teachers and have learned from them, if they then hear sūtras such as these — sūtras possessed of the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature), endowed with the nature of the Tathāgata's permanence — they will develop doubt and uncertainty, and their minds will go entirely astray. Having fallen into uncertainty and wrong views, they will, regardless of whether they slander the teacher of benefit or not, whether they express delight or approval, whether they show contempt or cause confusion, say and think such things as: "Is this something fabricated by him, or is this something done by Māra with the intention of corrupting the teaching?" Then, turning away from his presence, they will go each to their own regions and will corrupt one another's ethical discipline and views. They will not come to obtain sūtras such as these. Why is this? Because wherever a teacher of benefit is, sūtras such as these will arise there. At that time in this world, many, many sentient beings who see and hear this will come to denigrate the Great Vehicle — yet do not be discouraged. Why? Because this is the age of the five degenerations (Skt. pañcakaṣāya), an age in which the teaching will decline, and thus many sentient beings will come to denigrate the Great Vehicle most severely. For example, just as in a village of seven households there is but one wayfarer, in just the same way, wherever sūtras such as these are being practiced, among every seven persons, without fail, one will certainly come to reject the true Dharma.

It is like this: those of similar moral discipline, upon seeing those whose discipline has degenerated, will be pleased, and they will take delight in causing one another's discipline to degenerate. Now, who are those called "of similar moral discipline"? They are those who, having heard sūtras such as these and witnessing someone teaching the Dharma of those sūtras and the like, turn away with this thought in mind and speak words such as these: "What is all this talk in this vast sūtra about the realm of sentient beings having the essential nature of the Tathāgata, about something permanent, about inherent existence being permanent?" And so, looking the other way, they think: "These people here will become partisans of my side," and they cultivate mutual affection among themselves, gradually settling one another

into their own views, making their view one and the same as their own nature. For example, suppose a boy in the household of a brahmin or a householder falls into improper conduct. His father and mother try to turn him away from it, but when they try to turn him away from it he cannot be turned from that improper conduct, and in time he leaves his own home. Having left, he befriends another boy. Then that boy leads him along, and together they play with bows and arrows, or with balls, or with whatever other games there may be, and whatever that boy delights in, so too does he do. Then at some other time, that boy too, in his own delight, leaves his own home and, thinking "I will say such and such to them, and we will go off to another region," speaks words of that kind — this is what is called "those of similar moral discipline." Such persons will take no delight in sūtras such as these. They will take no delight in reading sūtras such as these, in teaching them to others, or in being with those who train others in them, or in those who so train others. Why is that? Because in such a time sentient beings will be impoverished in Dharma, and with minds that are defeated they will become slack. Then, at that time, wherever one who behaves as though in a similar age goes, there too they will denigrate. O Blessed One, such a wretched age will come to pass!

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, when such an age arrives, what manner of conduct, and of what nature, should those who teach benefit adopt? For example, suppose there is a field alongside a great road through a village, a town, or a market town, a field of abundant crops of legumes (the kind suitable for consumption by elephants, horses, and people), of mung beans, of black-eyed peas, and of sugarcane in full flourishing. A highway then runs straight through the middle of it because it is a thoroughfare, and the householder who owns the field stations a single guardian there. That guardian keeps watch for one day and then, growing self-satisfied, becomes negligent. And on the second day, the third day, the tenth day, the twentieth day, and even the hundredth day, it is the same. Then the last of those men reflects: "If I were to try to turn all of them back, that alone would not amount to my having guarded the field, nor would the harvest be accomplished. So let me think of a good method by which I can guard the field and think of a skillful means for dealing with those who are entering and consuming the field's harvest." Having reflected thus, he considers: wherever there are merely some legumes, or clusters of legumes, or bunches of legumes, or —

where those legumes exist, he should first welcome those who come forward with respect, address them as "brother," saying "Take some of this of mine,"

and give to them. By giving in that way and speaking in that way, the entire field will be accomplished. Kāśyapa, you too should likewise, after I have passed away, employ such a method and bring forth this sūtra.

Kāśyapa then said: Blessed One, by this enumeration I would be quite unable to properly take hold of ordinary people. Why is that? Blessed One, carrying Mount Meru, the king of mountains, as a load upon one's head for a hundred thousand eons — that I could manage. But listening to the harsh words of ordinary, morally degenerate people who slander the sacred Dharma, who revile the sacred Dharma — that I cannot manage. Blessed One, to be under someone else's thumb, to be controlled by another — that I could manage. But listening to the harsh words, the foul speech, and the grating words of those sentient beings — ordinary, morally degenerate people who have turned their backs on the sacred Dharma, who have grown distant from the sacred Dharma, who, not having grasped the hearing of the sacred Dharma, are beings of a degraded stream — that I cannot manage. Blessed One, for many tens of millions of hundreds of thousands of tens of millions of eons to carry upon one's head this great earth together with its oceans and mountains — that I could manage. But listening to the harsh words of those sentient beings — ordinary, morally degenerate people who utterly destroy the teaching, who praise themselves and disparage others — that I cannot manage. Blessed One, being deaf, being mute, being blind — that I could manage. But listening to the harsh words of those sentient beings — ordinary, morally degenerate people who, for the sake of earning a livelihood in times of famine, have shaved their heads and put on saffron robes and exert themselves in pursuit of food and drink — that I cannot manage. Blessed One, swiftly attaining complete nirvāṇa — that I could manage. But listening to the harsh words, the speech, and the words of those sentient beings — ordinary, morally degenerate people who roam about everywhere like wild asses, feigning composure in body and feigning composure in speech — that I cannot manage.

The Blessed One then declared: Kāśyapa, even if you attain complete nirvāṇa, will you not still be born again? Is that the ultimate of complete nirvāṇa?

Kāśyapa said: Blessed One, the path for sentient beings who, upon attaining complete nirvāṇa, will neither be born again nor perish — that path is threefold: it belongs to the śrāvakas, to the pratyekabuddhas, and to the fully awakened Blessed Ones.

Kāśyapa then asked further: Blessed One, what is it like to have attained complete nirvāṇa yet not to have reached the final culmination of complete nirvāṇa?

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, when śrāvakas attain complete nirvāṇa through the nirvāṇa of the śrāvakas, that is not the ultimate culmination of complete nirvāṇa. Why? Because they will again become pratyekabuddhas. And when pratyekabuddhas attain complete nirvāṇa through the nirvāṇa of the pratyekabuddhas, even that is not the ultimate culmination of complete nirvāṇa, so long as they have not yet reached the supreme culmination of the Mahāyāna nirvāṇa — the gnosis of omniscience endowed with the supreme of all aspects.

Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, how should one understand this?

The Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, take the example of cream from milk, butter from cream, clarified butter from butter, and from clarified butter the essence of butter. In that analogy, what is like the clarified butter are the bodhisattvas who have attained the tenth ground — because they still have residual afflictions. What is like butter are the śrāvakas. What is like the churning of butter are the pratyekabuddhas. And what is like the essence of butter — that is how the Tathāgatas are to be regarded.

Then Kāśyapa said:

Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, for what reason did the Tathāgata teach the three vehicles?

The Blessed One declared: Consider this example. A supremely skilled military strategist, expert in illusion, sets out from his own land to travel to another. A great crowd of people follows along with him, and another great crowd follows as well — all of them wishing to cross over in many ways. He is the guide and teacher for most of those travelers, and he himself is their caravan leader. As he leads that company out of that wilderness, in order to give them relief he conjures by magical illusion a magnificent city complete with enclosures, open courtyards, and upper terraces, and pointing toward it from a great distance he speaks these words: "Friends, the city we are all heading to is right over there." Hearing this, they think they have drawn near, and understanding that the village, city, or market town is close and will serve as a resting place, they become greatly heartened. Then, having entered that city and rested comfortably there, their spirits settle and they feel no urge to travel on to the next town. Then the guide thinks to himself: "These beings are feeble, of weak

effort, and are content with this trifling comfort — I should make this city disappear." When they discover that the city has vanished, they say to the guide: "Was that an illusion? Was it a dream? Was it a lie? Was it real?" The guide, hearing this from them, speaks these words: "Sons of good family, I conjured that city by illusion in order to give you rest. Now we must press on to the supreme great city where we are truly to dwell — let us go to wherever that other city lies." And they say: "Very well, if that is what we are to do, let us go on to that ordinary city on the outskirts." The rest of this should be understood as before. Then again another great city is conjured, and the same thing happens there too.

Then the guide, having thus delivered the travelers from that wilderness and given them such relief, leads them into that city. Once they have entered, they begin to wonder: "Might there be yet another city, far surpassing this one, beyond it?" The guide perceives their thought: "These people wish to remain in this very city." So the guide says to them: "Friends, beyond this city there is indeed another that is supremely distinguished and excellent — it is the final destination of all cities, and there is no other city like it." When the travelers place their trust in the caravan leader's words, they hear and see more and more of the qualities and distinctions of that city, and they say to the guide: "Friend, let us all go together to that great city which is the final destination of all cities." The guide replies: "Excellent! Let us all go together." Then, as the guide is delivering those travelers from that wilderness and addressing the great multitude of people, he declares: "Sons of good family, you shall now come to see the omens of that great city, the great city itself, and the city of abundant joy." And as the guide delivers the travelers from that wilderness, gives them relief, and shows them the city from a great distance, he speaks these words:

"Friends, look upon the omens of that great city." And as that great multitude of people see the prosperity and abundance of resources in those lands, regions, and city, and behold the great city itself, they become joyful and delighted, they look at one another in astonishment, and they wonder: "Could there be another city, a luminous great city of great cities, like this one, elsewhere?"

Then the Teacher spoke these words to them: "Friends, this great city is a luminous one, supremely exalted above all cities. It is a city of great cities, full of joy, permanent, stable, peaceful, free from aging, free from death, joyful always, joyful continually, joyful without interruption." Having thus given them

relief, he spoke further: "Enter now the great city of great cities." And as the multitude of people entered, he spoke again: "Friends, this supreme great city is the final destination of all cities, and beyond this city there is no other city."

Then, as they entered that great city, they became filled with wonder and amazement, and in great delight they said to the Teacher, "Excellent! Excellent!" — offering him that salutation — "You who are fortunate, possessed of great wisdom and great compassion, who show us loving care." And then they asked the Teacher further: "Fortunate one, do all those cities through which we passed still exist, or do they not?"

The Teacher replied: "Those cities were for the sake of giving relief. If a place is an empty place, and that empty place has no purpose, then what is the use of saying 'we shall depart from there' — because it is an empty city. The form of the city, its enclosures, and its upper storeys are like a first emanation: they are the vehicle of the śrāvakas, the pure and clear ones of this kind, namely the sūtras of emptiness. The other kind, somewhat obscure, is the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas. And buddhahood itself is the luminous liberation. Therefore the buddha Blessed Ones teach three kinds of discourse in three vehicles, and they teach nirvāṇa as well in three modes, while also teaching the single vehicle.

"Kāśyapa, whoever says that sūtras such as these do not exist — that one's teacher is not me, and that one is not my śrāvaka."

A question was put: "Blessed One, in the Great Vehicle as well there are many sūtras that teach the meaning of emptiness."

The Blessed One declared: "Whatever teachings on emptiness there may be, all of them are to be understood as having an intended meaning. But sūtras such as these — the unsurpassed ones of this kind — are to be understood as not having an intended meaning.

"Kāśyapa, furthermore, consider this: Prasenajit, king of Kosala, at the last month of winter — at the time when the last month of winter comes round, the king gives to the dead, the destitute, the afflicted, wandering ascetics (śramaṇas), brahmins, beggars of various classes, and others: sugar cane, cooked grain, butter, sesame, condiments, gruel, an all-mixed dish, and things made from all kinds of grain. When he gives, some among them desire gruel, some desire sour things, and some desire the all-mixed dish. He gives all of it to all of them. And of them, some eat the all-mixed food; others, concentrating on achieving the flavor of individual items — a measure of kidney beans, a

cluster of kidney beans, or shallots — eat and drink them one by one with relish."

Then, after that, his mind became troubled, and he said: "Let no one eat what I have eaten." And just as the fine, warm food that was available there he gave to his beloved child, or a man, or a townsperson, or one of his own people, or to others — in the same way, Kāśyapa, when I teach sūtras of various intentions to sentient beings of various inclinations, those among them who are slack in conduct, undisciplined, and unrestrained in body, speech, and mind abandon sūtras such as this one — on buddha-nature, on the permanence of the buddhas — and take up study of the sūtra chapters on emptiness. And among them, some copy out the words and letters, while others mutually abandon words and letters. Why is that? Because from among all the words of the buddha, it is emptiness and selflessness that are taught. Those foolish people who do not understand the meaning of emptiness and selflessness will come to ruin.

Furthermore, emptiness and selflessness in the speech of the buddhas is nirvāṇa — ever empty of afflictions in the millions — and nirvāṇa itself is the basis of all those textual foundations; for those buddha Blessed Ones have attained a nirvāṇa that is pacified and everlasting.

The question was asked: "Blessed One, how does one seek annihilation and permanence?"

The Blessed One declared: "For as long as sentient beings wander in saṃsāra, I enter in. The meaning of the view of selflessness is everlastingness and permanence. If that permanence is denied, everlastingness is diminished."

"Blessed One, furthermore, selflessness has existed for a long time, whereas the self has not existed for a long time."

The Blessed One declared: "I teach selflessness in order to destroy what worldly people call 'a self.' If it were not taught in the teaching guiding that kind of conduct, how could what has perished be known to have perished? It is well known that the buddha Blessed One teaches no-self." Astonishment arose, and then, with hundreds and thousands of reasons and arguments, one enters the teaching. Having thus been introduced, whenever faith arises and one enters into the teacher who is superior, one takes up, strives in, and makes effort in the phenomena of emptiness.

After that, liberation is then taught to them as: peaceful, permanent, and possessed of form. Furthermore, certain worldly people say, "Liberation exists," and in order to destroy that view I taught: "Liberation is utterly non-existent." If, in teaching it thus, the Teacher did not teach as though causing a mistaken view to be swallowed, how could one come to trust in the Teacher's teaching? Therefore, with hundreds and thousands of reasons and arguments, the no-self that causes liberation to be swallowed as a mistaken view was taught.

Then after that, seeing the view that liberation is a mistaken thing to be swallowed would cause foolish people to fall into ruin, I then again, with hundreds and thousands of reasons and arguments, taught that liberation does indeed exist.

The question was asked: "If liberation is attained and you are the Lord, then sentient beings too exist — and that, I understand, is established. Why is that? For, while still enmeshed in smoke, if liberation were everlastingly a self, then one who speaks of a self in liberation would speak just as one who speaks of it as possessed of form — but it is neither like the worldly person's view of the transitory collection (*satkāyadr̥ṣṭi*), nor like the speech of those who assert annihilation and permanence."

Kāśyapa then also asked: "Blessed One, if the Tathāgatas have no final passing into complete *nirvāṇa*, why do they demonstrate such a complete passing into *nirvāṇa*? And if there is no arising, why demonstrate birth? If sentient beings were for a time to err even with respect to the buddhas —"

What need is there even to speak of us? One will come to understand that even the buddhas have not mastered the self, to say nothing of those of us held fast by the grasping at "I" and the grasping at "mine."

It is like a king who was seized by a vassal king, thrown in irons, and cast into prison. That king then reflected: "I am a king. I am a lord." But then he thought again: "I am not — for apart from heedlessness, what is there in this suffering?" In just the same way, as long as one wanders in *saṃsāra*, one views with the thought "I am a self," and this is the meaning of the view of no-self.

It is also like a murderous robber brandishing a sword who pursues someone step by step. The one being pursued then thinks: "Can I escape from this robber's hands?" — and realizes that he has no mastery over his own body. In just the same way, sentient beings afflicted by the manifold sufferings of birth,

aging, sickness, and death think: "May I become a sovereign, or Brahmā!" This Tathāgata demonstrates dying in order to shatter such conceptual grasping.

Moreover, the Tathāgata is the god above gods. If the Tathāgata were to pass completely into nirvāṇa and cease to exist in that way, it would appear that the world itself was going out. But if the world does not go out, then the support persists in peace. And if there is such a support, one must understand that the self exists — like fire inferred from smoke. But then again, if what lacks a self were to become a self, one would have to understand that the world was increasing. Yet even if the self were truly real, it would still not be a self, and it would not perish. And if no-self were true, a self would not be tenable.

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, what is meant by 'existence'?"

The Blessed One declared: "What is called 'existence' is the twenty-five modes of conduct of sentient beings. What is called 'non-existence' is a thing devoid of mind. If what is without mind were to become a sentient being, that would imply coming from elsewhere. If what has mind were to be destroyed, that would imply going out. If what is without mind were to become a sentient being, that would imply increase. Therefore neither of these two arises, nor do they degrade — and for that reason there is neither decrease nor increase."

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, how am I to understand that the self exists?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, excellent, excellent! But such a question as that should not be asked. Kāśyapa, it is like a goldsmith who sees an ore of gold and thinks: 'At some point this gold became impure. Let me seek the original boundary of that gold's impurity.' Could he ever find that original boundary? Blessed One, he could not. And if he were to go on contemplating the original marks and signs of that impurity for as long as he lives, searching without end, he would still not find any boundary — and neither could he take up the gold. But if through vigorous effort and skillful means he were to purify that impurity, only then could he take up the gold; he could never do so through sheer weariness and despondency."

"Kāśyapa, in just the same way, understand that the afflictions that have adventitiously overtaken the self are like that. Moreover, there are those who, wishing to assert a self-view, think: 'Let me first search for my afflictions and for their beginning and end.' Could they find anything? Blessed One, they could not. But if one were to purify the afflictions, after that one would find the self."

That self, too, cannot be found merely by hearing sūtras of that kind. Rather, it is through skillful means, without weariness, through sustained inquiry and vigorous effort, and through the three paths, that one will attain it — and only then will one come to have confidence in sūtras such as these.

Then Kāśyapa asked further: "Blessed One, if a self does exist, why has it come to be as it is, obscured by these adventitious afflictions?"

The Blessed One replied: "Kāśyapa, I will give you an analogy. Suppose someone learns the five syllables of the alphabet and is thereby made to understand the meaning of words that arise from the domain of language, or the meaning of verses, and is told, 'Study further.' Would that person understand through that alone? If they study progressively, they would understand in due course. But when someone has trained well over a long time, then when their teacher speaks before an assembly about the meaning of the words that arise from the domain of language, no analogy need be shown to them — they are certainly able to listen. If one trusts and has confidence in what one's own teacher says, exactly as those words from the domain of language arise, then afterward one will understand the meaning and come to have confidence in it.

In just the same way, today I describe such a sentient being — one whose mind is covered by the encasement of tens of millions of afflictions — as possessing tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature). Now, if someone wished to see it directly, could they see it? Could those beings perceive it?"

Kāśyapa replied: "Blessed One, they could not — it is inaccessible."

"Just as the student who places trust and faith in the teacher will afterward come to know the foundation of the meaning of words that arise from the domain of language, so too, Kāśyapa, you must understand this: the Tathāgata speaks truth, speaks words of truth — and when he declares that sentient beings truly exist, know this just as the student who has completed the training will understand it afterward.

Kāśyapa, I will give you another analogy. These four are the causes and logical instances for showing that the buddha-element is obscured within the realm of sentient beings. What are the four? They are like an eye afflicted with a yellow and blue cataract, like the moon covered by clouds, like the digging of a well, and like a lamp inside a jar.

These same four are also the causes and logical instances for the assertion that a buddha-nature exists. Through these causes and instances, the buddha-element is present in all sentient beings and all living beings — it will become manifest, adorned with boundless excellent major and minor marks — and through that element, sentient beings will attain nirvāṇa.

With regard to an eye afflicted with a cataract: an eye diseased with a yellow and blue cataract is treatable — yet for as long as a physician is not found, the person remains blind; and when a physician is found, sight quickly returns. In the same way, the element obscured by the encasement of tens of millions of afflictions — for as long as one takes delight in śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, the self will not be a true self but will be a self belonging to something other. But when one comes to take delight in the buddha Blessed Ones, then it becomes a true self, and thereafter one becomes a person worthy of liberation. The afflictions should be understood as being like the eye disease of yellow and blue cataract, and the tathāgatagarbha is certainly present, like the eye itself.

With regard to the moon covered by clouds: just as the disc of the moon is invisible when covered by thick clouds, so too this element is invisible when covered by the encasement of afflictions. But when the gathered clouds of affliction are dispelled, the element will become visible, like a clear full moon."

With regard to the example called "digging a well": just as when a man digs and digs a well, the more dry earth he encounters, the more he knows by that sign that the water is still far away, and when he reaches moist earth he knows by that sign that water is near — and when he finally strikes water, the digging has reached its end — so too the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, pleasing the Tathāgatas and practicing virtuous conduct as the Teacher shows them, dig through the afflictions. And by digging in this way, they will discover the tathāgatagarbha, just as one discovers water.

With regard to the example called "the lamp inside a vessel": just as a lamp burning inside a vessel gives off no bright, blazing light, sheds no radiant glow, and does nothing of any benefit for sentient beings — yet when the vessel is shattered, the lamp shines forth of itself and comes to be of benefit to living creatures — so too the tathāgatagarbha, said to be endowed with boundless major marks and excellent features, while dwelling within the vessel of saṃsāra whose hollow shell is composed of countless afflictions, blazes forth like a lamp. And when the afflictions of saṃsāra are exhausted, it becomes,

like the lamp when the vessel is broken, a Tathāgata who acts for the benefit of sentient beings.

By means of these four lines of reasoning, one should understand that just as the element of sentient beings is present in me, so it is present in all sentient beings. In this regard, what is called the element that is worthy of being actualized should be understood as that which abides as singular. This arises from each of the one hundred and eight lines of reasoning explained above, each arranged into groups of eight verses.

A question was then posed: "Blessed One, for what reason did the Tathāgata teach the three vehicles?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, I will give you an example. Consider a householder who possesses vast wealth and has a single son. That son is lost in a great crowd, taken from his mother's arms. When the time of the householder's death draws near, he thinks: 'My son is lost. I have no other son, no father, no mother, no sibling born together with me, no one of the household — and so these treasuries of my wealth will be taken by the king.' He turns this thought over and over in his mind.

After a long time has passed, the lost son comes to that very city and enters his father's house in search of food, not knowing, 'This house is my father's house.' The moment the father sees him, he thinks: 'This is indeed my proper son' — yet he says not a single word to him, such as 'You are my son.' Why? Because, he reasons, 'He might flee again, and that would not do.' So the father gives him a great abundance of wealth from his treasuries.

But the son says to him: 'I cannot bear to remain in your house. Why? Because remaining in your house feels to me like being bound with the binding of a noose — it is suffering.' Then the householder says: 'What shall I do?' And the son replies: 'Let me tend your calves, gather your grass, sweep and clean, or plow your fields of grain.'

The householder then reflects: 'Alas — a being who has made no merit! There is nothing to be done but to make him gradually understand, in his own time.' So he says: 'Very well, for now just gather those bundles of rags and sweep.'

Later, at another time, while the man is sweeping and cleaning, he is seen to be indulging in many pleasures, taking delight and experiencing agreeable sensations. Seeing this, the householder thinks: 'Will the master now give me many treasuries of wealth, or —'

'Or perhaps if he wishes to make me his own son, why not?' Thinking thus, the man no longer merely sweeps the bundles of rags carelessly. At that time the father, seeing him going about his work in this way, thinks: 'My son now has good fortune.' And so the father speaks to his son with these words: 'Hey! Are you thinking of something else today? Why do you not do your work well?' The man replies: 'It is just so. Today I myself wish to be acknowledged as your son — and for that reason my mind has today come to be filled with such faith.' The father says: 'Excellent! I am your father, and you are my son. Did you not know that I have always wanted to benefit you and have cherished you with affection?' Then the father gave him all his many treasuries of wealth, over which he has independent mastery, and in the midst of a great gathering of people he made this publicly known, saying: 'This is my one and only son. He was lost long ago, and now he has returned, entered his own home, yet did not know or understand that this was his father's house. At that time, though he did not even desire the name of "you are my father, I am your son," now at this very moment I declare in words that he is my son.' At that point a great multitude of people marveled, saying: 'How wonderful! Sentient beings are afflicted by the many kinds of karma!'

Kāśyapa, in just the same way, all of my śrāvaka disciples also originally knew themselves to be like the son who swept the bundles of rags, and with astonishment they said: 'How amazing! O Blessed One, because we did not seek you out as our own father, the vehicle of the śrāvakas is but the lesser for us!'

Therefore, Kāśyapa, you should train in this way: if for the time being you are able to fully relinquish these, whether by rebuke or by reproach, you should know that this is the arrival of the right time for the ripening of those disciples. Therefore, out of compassion for them, you should become skilled in all skillful means for the sake of guiding them to the Great Vehicle. Those who have no faith should come to have faith, and those who already have faith should come to have full confidence. You should gather and hold all of them by means of the four ways of gathering disciples.

Kāśyapa, furthermore, if a certain person here is struck only by an epidemic, or by a severe epidemic, in such a case medicine should not be given to that person and an examination should not be carried out. Why? Because the physician who does not know these two things — when it is the right time to act and when it is not, even if it is the right time to act — is someone who is condemned in the world. Therefore, examine when the illness is ripe and bide

your time when it is not. In just the same way, whatever sentient beings pursue the abandonment of these ways, those are to be thoroughly disciplined. But when the time comes that their illness has ripened, and after that they themselves recall it and understand: 'We were treated harshly!' — at that point they are to be examined and drawn into the vehicle of the śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

End of the fourth fascicle of the chapter on the noble Great Drum.

Kāśyapa, you should moreover hold and grasp all of those sūtra passages that speak of abandonment. Why? Because if those abandonments are carried out at the right time and in the right spirit, that itself constitutes the fulfillment of the utmost longing for them. Therefore, out of loving care for them, you should become skilled in all skillful means for the purpose of guiding them to the Great Vehicle. Those who have no faith should come to have faith, and those who already have faith should come to full confidence. You should gather and hold all of them by means of the means of gathering.

But if that is not possible, give them white robes and send them away, or else train them by other stages and methods. Why? Because out of loving care for them above all, whatever is suitable may be used to set them on the Great Vehicle. Sentient beings should be brought to the Great Vehicle by two means. What are those two? By reasoning and by admonition. Therefore, set them on it either by reasoning or by admonition. If they are set on it in this way, the bodhisattva, the great being, will tread the first ground and come to abide on that first ground. And if one engages in that way and speaks accordingly, one attains the second ground — which is to say, this constitutes a single prophecy of awakening. For example, when a person is released from prison, would they return to prison again? In the same way, one who has emerged from the vehicle of the hearers and entered the path of the Great Vehicle — would they come to touch the vehicle of the hearers again?

Kāśyapa replied: That will not happen. Such a person would strike the ground in rage and anguish.

Then the Blessed One declared: Kāśyapa, you should know the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature, the essence of the Tathāgata). Kāśyapa, do not weep in that way. Kāśyapa, for example, when the thing itself is seen, no proof through inference is needed. Just as when one sees an āmalaka fruit directly, there is no need to say "this here is an āmalaka," whereas for someone who has not yet seen it, a reasoned demonstration of the āmalaka is

needed — and just as people in the south need to be shown a person painted in a picture, while people in the north need no such showing, because they have seen it before — in the very same way, you too have seen the tathāgatagarbha directly, as clearly as an āmalaka fruit.

Kāśyapa, furthermore, during my lifetime and during your lifetime, those who abandon or will abandon this sūtra — if you are able, you should chastise them and take hold of them. Having thus chastised and seized them, set them on the Great Vehicle by reasoning or admonition, treating them as your own children, or as those dear to you, or as those whom you love as much as yourself. Kāśyapa, all those who follow the vehicle of the hearers are also my children. I matured every single one of them when I myself was engaged in practice in former times — across countless, immeasurable eons beyond measure, and then beyond that, when the Tathāgata known as Kinsman of the World arose. At that time, in that era, the teaching of the single vehicle was expounded from this great sūtra. At that time, all of those present — and all the others besides — would reject it. They would band together as one, then go about in anger, slander, and reproach. Seeing this, I thought: these are my children, my disciples; it would not be right to drive them away when their time has not yet come. I must think of a skillful means to pacify them as needed. Then, having come to know their capacities and their lack of capacity, I taught them teachings of this kind. For those who had not come to have faith in the Great Vehicle, I spoke teachings of the vehicle of the hearers, holding the understanding that the culmination and final word is this — the Great Vehicle — while the remainder is the vehicle to be abandoned. Though women may practice good conduct well, they do not attain liberation; and the same holds for townspeople. One who knows how to ride a horse and rides at a gallop will arrive quickly at a village or a city; but if a child goes step by step on foot, will that child not also arrive in the end?

Just as a young child eats butter and food with a finger, and a strong person fills a vessel and eats in that way, so too I, Kāśyapa, gathered those who did not desire the Great Vehicle, and at that time I taught them the Great Vehicle by means of the vehicle of the hearers — like a servant who sweeps with a bundle of rags. Whatever karma of belittlement they had accumulated against it, once they entered the Great Vehicle through my preceding cultivation of loving-kindness toward them, for some it will be exhausted in that very body through nothing more than an illness, or sorrow, or mere mental discomfort. Those who at that time did not listen to or accept my words were harmed

through their wrong conduct. Thus, Kāśyapa, just as those hearers are like a servant sweeping with a bundle of rags, all of them are nonetheless my children — and this they will come to know now at last.

Then the great Kāśyapa exclaimed: "How wonderful! Blessed One, we have only now at last made a decisive break from the vehicle of the hearers, as one who has found their own true parents!"

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, it is precisely for this reason that I have said to you: you will come to know later — do what you wish and do not abandon your endeavor. If you find yourself unable, then let it be. Kāśyapa, you should train in this way: even if they grow angry and revile you, you should bear with it. Consider this example. There is a stream, or a ditch, or a pond, or a small lake, or a pool, or a well. A man, a woman, a boy, a girl, or any number of sentient beings come carrying whatever vessels they have, draw exactly as much water as they need, and go. Whether the vessel is a jug, a clay pot, or a gourd — if the vessel breaks there is nothing at all to be found in it. Is a noble son to be angry with the gourd for producing a gourd, or with the jug for producing a jug? And what is there to be angry with over emptiness? In just the same way, noble son, you yourself aroused the power of your own capacity, entered the vehicle of the hearers, and came to dislike and reject the Great Vehicle, saying, 'What do I need with it?' Furthermore, consider this example: a king eats food from a gold and silver dish; hungry ghosts and the poor eat fruit and roots; a householder eats according to his own means. Does this bring reproach upon the king? Whatever happiness or suffering any being has brought about through whatever deeds will become clear to them, and they should dwell with that. Likewise, even if you lack the power to enter the Great Vehicle, why should you obstruct it? Furthermore, a king gives silver, gold, pearls, jewels, beryl, crystal, coral, and the like; and the poor give a beggarly morsel of food. Those who are learned hold scripture, and those of lesser intelligence have only their own limited range. Others run to a great city many leagues away, while children cannot run even half a fathom — should those young children be beaten for not being able to run as fast? Who would be at fault in that? Kāśyapa, furthermore, a village woman delights in her village, while a woman of a great city delights in her city. Kāśyapa, in just the same way the Tathāgata teaches the Dharma to sentient beings in accordance with their individual vessel and capacity."

Then the great Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One, saying: "Blessed One, I have a question about the Dharma to ask." The Blessed One declared:

"Ask it." "It concerns the views of sentient beings — what are the views of sentient beings? What are they like?" The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, consider this example. Some people set out from a great city called Yutsamba toward the great city of Śrāvastī, and they took up lodging in a village settlement not very far at all from the great city of Śrāvastī. Then one of them asked another traveler —"

"Friend, how do things stand in Śrāvastī? Is one able to find there a woman — in a household, a lodging-house, or an inn — to stay with?"

Then that man, being skilled in means and knowing the minds of others, observed through divine sight the one who was approaching. And he understood: "This wicked one has abandoned his virtuous spiritual teacher, disregarding his own mother's hardship. He has listened to the words of a lying fellow and set out for Śrāvastī, thinking, 'I shall go there and sport with a courtesan.'" Having understood this in his mind, he then said to that man:

"Friend, it would be well for you to turn back quickly the way you came. People like you — those who turn back from the right path — King Prasenajit (Prasenajit, the king of Kosala) will hand over to rākṣasas as food. Friend, turn back quickly!"

Then that man, heeding these words, ran swiftly to wherever his home was. He went there, fell at his mother's feet, and begged her forgiveness.

Then at another time that man's mother died, and he took all the wealth that now belonged to him freely and set out toward Śrāvastī. That very same man saw the other approaching. Having seen him and reflected on what was coming, he thought: "If he goes there and distributes all his property to the dead, the poor, the destitute, the beggars, and the like, and makes offerings, shows reverence, and renders devotion to the Tathāgata, and has gradually brought himself to have no attachment and no pride — and then, for as long as he desires, sports with a courtesan, rejoices and takes pleasure, and thereafter goes forth in renunciation under the teaching of the Tathāgata" — this is what he understood.

That man asked him: "Friend, what is the great city of Śrāvastī like these days?"

He replied: "Friend, the city of Śrāvastī is beautiful and pleasing, joyful and delightful to behold. It has a fine assembly of courtesans from the best regions of the land. It is prosperous, flourishing, happy, and pleasant."

Kāśyapa — when he speaks like that, is he telling a lie?

Kāśyapa replied: "Blessed One, certainly."

The Blessed One declared: "It is not so."

"Then what is it, Blessed One?"

The Blessed One declared: "It is skillful means."

The Blessed One further declared: "The Tathāgata has taught that one may speak a small untruth through various categories of synonyms."

Kāśyapa asked: "For what purpose, Blessed One?"

"Kāśyapa, you and the noble young woman Bhaṅgamā were once a married couple wandering in saṃsāra. Bhaṅgamā's father and mother said to each other — and thought: 'Will our two children pursue the pleasures of the senses together, or will they not?' They asked a household servant, and when the servant approached the household and was asked in turn: 'In this world, who is there that does not pursue and enjoy the pleasures of forms, sounds, smells, tastes, and touches, and delight in them?' — did you hear the servant speak those words?"

Kāśyapa replied: "Blessed One, that was not a lie on my part."

"In the same way, in this case too it can be designated a category of skillful means, and both parties should be pleased by this category of synonyms."

Kāśyapa said: "Blessed One, even if we were born as cedar trees for five hundred lives, as small ones we would not have slept crookedly in a borrowed place."

The Blessed One declared: "That is indeed just so and not otherwise — and that too is the skillful means of a person."

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, what is meant by skillful means?"

The Blessed One declared: "What is called skillful means means speaking in a way that is contradictory between the earlier and the later, and contradictory between the later and the earlier. By way of meaning it is not so."

"And why is that?"

Buddhas speak by whatever skillful means will accomplish the aim — by those very means, either with definitive meaning or with provisional meaning.

Kāśyapa asked: "What is meant by 'the aim is accomplished'?"

The Blessed One declared: "What is called 'the aim is accomplished' is to be understood as 'the Dharma is accomplished.'"

Kāśyapa asked: "The Tathāgata spoke a few synonyms to the effect that monks should also accept what is not permitted by valid cognition. If that is so, would one then accept it?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, that is not the reason."

Kāśyapa asked: "Why not? Is it in order to be separated from one's father's life? Or in order to be separated from one's own life for the sake of another? Or in order to be separated from one's father's life for the sake of one's mother?"

Kāśyapa said: "Blessed One, it is not so."

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, in just the same way, whatever one does that is neither for the father nor for the mother — that is what becomes the essence of the Tathāgata. Kāśyapa, just as it was said above in the manner of the man dwelling in the border region — although the self is real, I acted to negate the grasping at self. Why is that? Because that man had abandoned his own mother, and she too fell into suffering. He was separated from his own mother, and it was from that point that he sent back a message with those words, and mother and son were reunited. Thereafter, after the mother passed away, those who were now free — just as has been described — were shown the pleasures of desire, and thereafter went forth into the renunciant life.

"Likewise, O monks, if I had taught from the very beginning that the self exists, who would have gained faith? And had they gained faith, the grasping at self in the form of the view of the perishable collection (satkāyadṛṣṭi) is common to the world, and so it would merely become my own grasping. Therefore, just as the man dwelling in the border region, I first taught no-self, and thereafter taught the existence of the self — and I also taught the suchness of that self and its reality. Therefore, Kāśyapa, one must be skilled in skillful means.

"Kāśyapa, here is another example. A man traveled from a great road into a desolate wilderness, and a bird cried out with the call called 'catch the thief.' The man, traveling along the road, heard that bird's cry and thought, 'Has a thief appeared?' Terrified by fear of a thief, he fled off course and ended up in a wilderness where tigers dwelt, and there he suffered through misfortune.

"Kāśyapa, in just the same way, in the future, monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen — at the mere sound of the words 'self' and 'mine' — will take the worldly view of the perishable collection to mean no-self, and they will become

proponents of the view of annihilation, thinking that great emptiness is a cutting off. Thus they will not come to have faith in sūtras of this kind, which teach that the Tathāgata is permanent, that the buddha is permanent, and that the self possesses permanence.

"Kāśyapa, here is yet another example. There was a foolish farmer who had never before seen the great city of Śrāvastī. When he entered it, he saw men and women of beautiful form, lovely and pleasing to behold. Seeing them, unable to avert his eyes, he gazed at the noble sons and noble daughters. Having gazed his fill, he came back out, and then went to whatever house he was staying at, and said to the other foolish farmers: 'The king is like this — the forms of the women there are like those of divine daughters, and the forms of the men of quality are like those of divine sons.' On hearing this, the other common people thought to themselves, 'The king must have seen divine sons and daughters.' Then the king's emissaries, hearing these words, declared that idle and worthless talk had been spoken, and had him killed."

"Kāśyapa, in the same way, when the Tathāgata, the fully awakened buddha, passes into nirvāṇa itself — at that time, teaching the basis of the word 'self,' he teaches what is permanent, stable, peaceful, and everlasting. Yet whatever that self is like when beyond the world, the self that has been habituated to the worldly view of the transitory collection will be exhausted, is being exhausted, will come to be exhausted. That view, being what it is, is not mine — therefore, the declaration that permanence and annihilation are abandoned was well spoken by me. Kāśyapa, if the Tathāgata were to say 'a self is born,' would that mean the Tathāgata is born? If he were to say 'I am hungry and need to eat,' would that mean he is hungry and needs to eat? Kāśyapa, the meaning is not one of contradiction between the earlier and later statements. The meaning is not a conflict in the sense of the words."

Kāśyapa asked: "How is that so, my Lord?"

The Blessed One replied: "Kāśyapa, I will give you an analogy. For example, a skilled dyer buys a plain piece of cloth, dyes it red, and sells it for a good price. Then later he buys it back for a higher price, dyes that very same cloth blue by over-dyeing it, and sells it to someone else, getting double the price for it. Kāśyapa, is that the same cloth, or is it a different one?"

"It is not a different one — it has simply been transformed."

"Kāśyapa, in the same way, just as in the case of the cloth, through the continuous stream of freshly accumulated merit, what is done later is like a

skilled dyer using the method of dye to change its color.

"Kāśyapa, here is another analogy. In a great city there was a virtuous monk of good moral discipline. At the time of his death, while wandering through a village or city on alms round, he saw a prostitute and became attached to her. Then he thought: 'I will give her the robe I am wearing and do such a thing.' Having resolved upon this, he tempted that prostitute with his robe, and since the prostitute was by nature desirous, she agreed to do likewise with him. Then a lay practitioner (upāsaka) skilled in means, seeing this, thought to himself: 'Alas! This virtuous monk, who has good moral discipline, has now come to break that discipline. It would be better for this monk to die in this body than to break his moral discipline. Therefore, may whatever wrong this entails fall upon me.' Having said something to confuse and bewilder him, he killed him at once. Kāśyapa, will that man go to hell?"

Kāśyapa replied: "That, Blessed One, is known only to you."

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, that man's sin of killing the ascetic and separating him from his life — if that sin were to strike gradually over four months and ripen and fully mature in that very same body — even so, Kāśyapa, one who is skilled in means and who speaks merely in words for the benefit of sentient beings incurs no fault. When one who truly exists speaks merely the words 'there is no self' as a negating statement, why need one even speak of it causing no change whatsoever? Kāśyapa, moreover, you put Ānanda to shame and then asked me: 'If existence obtains, then there is pleasure and suffering; but if it does not obtain, how could there be pleasure and suffering?' Kāśyapa, listen now to the meaning of that.

"The Tathāgata is without a concrete thing, without a sentient being, and yet is not subject to destruction."

Kāśyapa asked: "How is that so, my Lord?"

The Blessed One replied: "Kāśyapa, for example, near the king of mountains, the Himālayas (Skt. Himavat), there exists a mineral vein of precious jewel called 'Precious Gem of Infinite Luminous Radiance.' Then a jewel-assayer, examining that vein of precious gem, sees it, recognizes it, and takes it."

By means of a method like washing gold, its impurities are cleansed away and it is taken. Then, from the moment its impurities have been purified onward, no matter into what vessel that person places it — whether soil, or mud, or sand, or any other container — when that precious jewel is polished on the

outside in such and such a way, it will never become mixed with those original impurities as before. Why is this? Consider, for example, a lamp that a person carries wherever he goes: in each and every place, the darkness is dispelled, and the lamp itself shines with clarity alone.

Kāśyapa, in just the same way, that precious jewel, like gold, has become untainted by impurities; and moreover, that precious jewel — at night, through the condition of starlight and moonlight, will cause water to drip; while by day, in sunlight, it blazes like the color of fire, yet burns nothing whatsoever.

Kāśyapa, just so, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha, having arisen in the world and attained awakening itself, dispels the impurities of birth, aging, sickness, and death, and is completely freed from tens of millions of afflictions. When separated from all the impurities of habitual tendencies, he shines forth like a purified gem and becomes, like a lotus, unstained in every direction.

Kāśyapa, furthermore, whatever form the Tathāgata takes to appear in this world or that, though he appears in such worlds he manifests as an ordinary being — and yet, even appearing as an ordinary being, he is not stained by those faults of the lower realms, nor does he personally experience the pleasures and sufferings of gods and humans. "The pleasures and sufferings of gods and humans" refers to the five objects of desire. Suffering is what is to be abandoned, and the single culmination of liberation is supreme bliss.

Then the elder Kāśyapa said this: "Excellent, Blessed One, excellent! I have only now, from this very moment, come to possess fully what it means to have gone forth and received full ordination as a monk, and to have truly become an arhat. Now I shall remember what I have done for the Tathāgata and feel what I have done." For the Tathāgata had said to me these words: "Kāśyapa, come here. Give me half your seat so that the two of us may sit together on one seat." The meaning of those words is this: today the Blessed One has, in the midst of the fourfold assembly, granted me empowerment into the Great Vehicle.

Then among that assembly there were also those wearing the appearance and robes of monks with shaved heads and beards. There were those not laywomen yet wearing the appearance of laywomen, and those wearing forms of various colors, and those turned to one side, and poets, and those with cranelike necks, and animals, and those gazing upward, and those gazing downward. All of these had been blessed by Māra.

Then the venerable Ānanda said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this assembly is very pure — free of husks, free of chaff, abiding firm and solid like the heartwood of sandalwood. Why then have these ones entered into such an assembly?"

The Blessed One replied: "Ānanda, ask the elder Kāśyapa about that."

Ānanda, acknowledging the command with "Excellent, as you have instructed," listened and said this to the elder: "Venerable Kāśyapa, how have these ones entered into the assembly?"

Kāśyapa replied: "Ānanda, these are foolish men — they are Māra's retinue, who have come together with Māra."

"Ānanda, it was for this reason that I said to the Blessed One: 'Blessed One, just as a skilled farmer protects his fields, I shall not let the banner of guarding the sacred Dharma fall after the Tathāgata has passed.' Having said that, I also said: 'For that reason, I do not consider this great earth a burden to bear.'

At that time the Blessed One spoke to me thus: 'Kāśyapa, after I have passed, for as long as the teaching has not declined, you will be able to bring forth the sacred Dharma in the world.' In this way the Blessed One aroused in me an eager resolve.

Then I said to the Blessed One: 'For now, I shall bring forth the sacred Dharma for some forty years.' The Blessed One then said to me: 'Until then, will you enter meditative absorption? Are you not able to strive for as long as the teaching does not decline?'

Then the Blessed One spoke to me again: 'Kāśyapa, for now, go and search for Māra. If you find him, you will be able to bring forth the sacred Dharma, and you will also come to understand my intention.'

Ānanda, when I looked with the divine eye for wicked Māra, I could not see him and could not find him. It was as when, for example, a farmer in the city of Śrāvastī who has lost his son searches for him amidst a great multitude of people, and not finding him, grows weary and turns back. Ānanda, in the same way, when I searched, I did not find him. Having failed to find him, I said to the Blessed One: 'Blessed One, I have no eagerness to search for wicked Māra.' Having said this, I sat down to one side.

Thereafter, in the same manner, beginning from the most junior elder among the great śrāvakas — ranging from the great śrāvaka elders who follow the elder Mahākāśyapa, one by one, up to eighty great śrāvakas — each applied

the farmer's simile in verse, and if their verses were to be counted, they would number in the thousands. Then the bodhisattva Surakṣita (Bzang Skyong), Guhyaka (Phug Sbas), and the other five hundred bodhisattvas likewise searched and likewise did not find him. Their verses too should be counted in the same way.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the elder Mahākāśyapa: 'Kāśyapa, the reason why in the future it will not be possible to bring forth the sacred Dharma everywhere is this: when eighty years have passed since the sacred Dharma declined, in that very eightieth year, the bodhisattva Surakṣita from the southern direction, together with Guhyaka and the rest — the last one among all those five hundred bodhisattvas — will be the one to bring it forth. Therefore, for now, go and search for that one.'

He replied: 'Excellent. I searched, and that very one is the young Licchavi, Joy-of-All-the-World-to-Behold.'

The Blessed One declared: 'Kāśyapa, go to him, obtain his permission, and he will be able to search for Māra.'

Then Mahākāśyapa, together with the eighty great śrāvakas, Surakṣita, Guhyaka, and the rest, went to the young one and made it known to him: 'Young one, the Blessed One has indicated that you will be able to search for wicked Māra.' This was heard.

The young one then spoke thus to Mahākāśyapa, the chief of the assembly: 'Venerable Kāśyapa, I shall indeed search for wicked Māra. However, venerable Kāśyapa, among the great bodhisattvas — those beginning with Surakṣita and Guhyaka — Mañjuśrī, Avalokiteśvara, Mahāsthāmaprāpta (He Who Has Attained Great Power), Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin (He Who Clears Away All Obstacles),"

and Maitreya, and the rest — are there not enough for me? Venerable Kāśyapa, I am not Māra's cowherd. For the time being, let those who are rich in merit search."

Kāśyapa replied: "Young one, would not the subduing of wicked Māra itself be a source of merit?"

The young one answered: "Venerable one, if even I am unable to do so, then since you yourself are exceedingly learned, you should search."

Kāśyapa then reported the matter to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, what did the young one say when this was put to him?"

Kāśyapa reported: "Blessed One, the young one said: 'For the time being, let those who are rich in merit search thoroughly. After that, I will search for wicked Māra. For now, let the eighty great śrāvakas search. As for myself, I am a householder of lower caste, so I will search after them.' This is what he said, Blessed One."

Then when even those supreme śrāvakas — together with Surakṣita, Guhyaka, and the rest of the assembly of bodhisattvas — had searched, it was like a farmer's wife who has lost her child in the city: they came and stood to one side saying, "I found nothing, I found nothing."

Then the Blessed One called to the young one and declared: "Young one, you search for Māra."

The young one replied: "Blessed One, there is here a meritorious one — a daughter of the king of the earth-holders (nāga-kings), a young woman called Pañcaśuklā (Five-White). For her sake, the sounds of great drums, conches, and music are resounding as she comes."

Then the Blessed One addressed the entire assembly of bodhisattvas: "She who is called Pañcaśuklā, daughter of the king of the earth-holders, having defeated all the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) without receiving an answer to a single question — today, having completed seven days of this, she comes speaking thus: 'There is a queen of King Śuddhodana called Mahāmāyā, and her son, born of the Gautama lineage, is said to be called Rūpasambhava-buddha (Beautifully Formed Buddha). I shall go into his presence.' And so she comes."

Then as she arrived, at that moment the road from Śrāvastī all the way to the Jeta Grove became crowded with her retinue, and the sounds of great drums, conches, and music resounded all the way from Śrāvastī to the Jeta Grove.

The young one then said: "Blessed One, I am also searching for wicked Māra, and those rich in merit have spoken thus — so who will answer her question?"

Thereupon the Blessed One spoke this verse:

Let the steadfast person always give as to a son,
free from malice.

It is proclaimed that this is never a degradation.

Let the answer to this question be obtained.

Then the eighty great śrāvakas, together with Guhyaka and the rest of the assembly of bodhisattvas, recited this verse in unison by way of response:

Whoever gives with a mind entirely free from malice —
whether a wanderer or one endowed with moral discipline —
giving to friend and foe alike as though to a son:
in all cases, giving is praised.
Blessed One, Protector of the World,
whatever question of this kind you have spoken —
if we have not heard its like before,
let Mañjuśrī understand it for now.

Then the assembly of bodhisattvas led by Mañjuśrī likewise responded with that very same verse.

Then the Blessed One addressed the young Licchavi (Skt. Licchavī) Sarvalokadṛṣṭipriya — Joy of All the World's Sight: "Young one, receive the answer to the question you asked."

The young one replied: "Blessed One, please first grant permission for all these great elephants to answer in order of seniority."

Then five hundred royal maidens, together with the five royal maidens, bowed down before the Blessed One, made incomparable offerings to the Blessed One, and beat the great drums. Having beaten them, they spoke these words: "All those steadfast ones who have come wishing to hear the sūtra of the Great Drum — let them hear our drums sound out and receive an answer to that question."

The young one then said: "Blessed One, please grant permission for them to answer." But they replied: "Blessed One, woman is by nature unstable, and therefore we are not fit to answer on this matter without hesitation."

The young one then said: "Blessed One, if this woman is by nature young, and I have been born male, then should the question put by a woman be answered?" Pañcaśveta said: "Young one, you have entered the teaching of the Protector, and if you have heard the nature of reality itself — why do you still think 'I am male, not female'? Have you not abandoned that inverted perception?" He said: "Sister, how is that?" Then Pañcaśveta said: "For that very reason, Blessed One, when someone speaks in that way, they show the characteristic of inverted perception."

The young one then said to Pañcaśveta: "First, let this be put to the Blessed One, and after that let us speak about it together." Kāśyapa said: "Blessed One, the young one is speaking just so." The Blessed One declared: "For now, the young one alone shall answer."

The young one then asked: "Young girl, who are you?" She replied: "I am called Pañcaśveta." He asked: "Sister, have you then attained the five whites?" Pañcaśveta replied: "Phenomena have no names; names are conventionally designated by conceptual thought. O foremost of young ones, in the ultimate sense this is emptiness — understand it as such." The young one said: "Goddess, have you still not abandoned inverted perception? If something called 'young man' or 'young woman' is found here, state it quickly."

Pañcaśveta replied: "Young one, excellent, excellent! The question has now been resolved. From this it can be inferred that you will become a buddha in the world." He said: "Goddess, do you truly know that the question is resolved? Just as young man and young woman are exhausted and do not arise, in that very way you do not know — for you speak just as the śrāvakas speak, whereas this question is as Mañjuśrī has stated." Pañcaśveta said: "What is the analogy?" The young one replied: "Alas — just as some man who has mastered all the letters and then written his own name cannot read it back, so too Goddess Pañcaśveta does not know 'Pañcaśveta.'"

This concludes the noble Great Drum Sūtra, the fifth and final chapter, the fifth fascicle.

Then at that time the entire assembly of bodhisattvas, the hosts of celestial gods, and the assemblies of dragons shook, greatly shook, trembled, and greatly trembled in all ten directions. They all cried out "Excellent!" — praising that great act of worship — saying: "Excellent! Excellent, that this goddess, who with a single question cut through every wonder and led many hundreds and thousands of millions of living beings into the teaching of the Tathāgata, should today know the Sage and know all the questions that he has posed."

Then at that time all the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) who had been full of wonder abandoned each their own going-forth and went forth into the teaching of the Tathāgata. Those among them who did not take up the going-forth became lay practitioners (upāsakas).

Then the entire assembly, complete in all its members, gave praise to the youth, saying: "Excellent! Excellent, young one, that you have so well answered this question." The youth replied: "This is the power of the Blessed

One alone, not my own." The Blessed One declared: "I too know that verse just as it is known by 'Beloved of All the World.' And this is the manner of the verse's meaning:

A bodhisattva of the highest kind
should always keep a mind of harm in view.
That giving ever praised,
is not for honoring discipline's wayward ones.
Nor is love shown to enemies as to a child —
hear the many distinctions of these words.

The highest person, upon seeing a monk who has broken discipline, should always maintain a mind of harm toward such a one, and should not give even the slightest gift to them. For they are like enemies to the teaching. One should think: 'To this one, give; to this one, do not give' — keeping this in mind for the sake of living beings. Giving has been taught in two kinds: giving to ordinary persons who possess moral discipline, and giving out of compassion to sentient beings who are suffering. But if one gives out of compassion to those who have broken discipline, will that not lead to contamination? Just as an arrow smeared with poison contaminates even what has not been smeared, so too a monk who has broken discipline causes even those who do possess moral discipline to fall into decline. Therefore, with regard to such a person, only censure is proper — how could giving be appropriate? Whenever one sees such a person, one should treat them consistently as an enemy — and thus it was said: do not produce a mind of harm toward them, meaning rather that one must be resolute, not warm.

Do not follow a guide of broken discipline —
for that very reason, a mind
of harm is to be generated,
so the buddhas of old have declared.

One who treats friend and enemy equally,
one who treats the negligent and the disciplined equally,
one whose conduct is without a mind of harm —
all such persons are to be regarded as weeds in this teaching.

For the teaching has a definitive meaning.
Conduct praised in just this way
must be practiced with keenest edge,
like the blade of a razor at its sharpest point.

Therefore the proclamation of the Great Drum sūtra has been made. What was that proclamation of the Great Drum sūtra? Whatever the meaning of that verse, it is spoken here in the Great Drum sūtra — and for that reason this great sūtra is called the Great Drum.

Then the entire assembly that had gathered gave praise, saying: "Excellent! Alas, young one, Beloved of All the World — just as the wise king Prasenajit, for the benefit of beings, sounds the drum on the battlefield, so too, when this Great Drum sūtra is proclaimed, it sounds forth to beings in the manner of proclaiming the praise of the Three Jewels, and it proclaims this secret of the buddha's speech: 'The Tathāgata is permanent, stable, peaceful, and everlasting' — this secret of the buddhas is proclaimed."

Then the Blessed One spoke once more to Mahākāśyapa: "Kāśyapa, at that time when Māra is unable to undermine the teaching, you, Kāśyapa, should listen to this Great Drum sūtra and, for forty years after my passing, uphold the sacred Dharma just as it abides now. Strike the great drum of the great Dharma! Proclaim the great drum of the great Dharma and sound the conch! After that, at eighty years, the sacred Dharma will be thoroughly destroyed. At that time, at that very moment, the youth Beloved of All the World — it will be at that time that those sentient beings first turned by Māra, those with their hair and beards shaved, will be dwelling there; and at that time the youth, together with his sinful retinue, bearing form, bound with the five bonds, will appear like a great mountain and will proclaim the great Dharma spoken in the Great Drum sūtra."

The great drum of the great Dharma will be struck. The conch of the great Dharma will be sounded. A Dharma-offering will be performed. The victory banner of the Dharma will be raised.

A question was asked: "When will this be, O Blessed One?"

The Blessed One declared: "It will be at that time when, at eighty years, the sacred teaching is in decline."

A question was asked: "Blessed One, if we are to see this, please let it be shown to us directly, right now."

Then the Blessed One said to the youth: "Quickly, show us the Māra."

The youth then turned away from the direction where the Blessed One was and said to the Blessed One: "The sinful Māra is present — coming from another world-realm, appearing in the form of a monk while resembling a

bodhisattva." And with his finger he pointed.

The entire assembly together with all its members also saw that Māra bound there, bound with the five bonds.

Then Māra said: "Youth, I will not obstruct this sūtra twice." He said these words three times.

The youth said: "How shall we be convinced of this?"

Māra said: "Be convinced in this way: whatever means he uses to make them appear as Māra's own side and thereby turn the faith of sentient beings — all those means shall be revealed. Youth, I will teach nirvāṇa for those from stream-enterer up to and including the four fruits, and I will also demonstrate the complete nirvāṇa of a buddha. I will speak of cultivating great emptiness, and I will also speak of the view that sentient beings exist; I will also assert the view of sentient beings, saying 'sentient beings do exist.' I will also show my own body blazing in the sky, billowing with smoke, and sending down a great rain of flowers. And all that I have described as 'great emptiness' — all of that is actually peace; and all that I have described as 'sentient beings exist' — all of that is emptiness. Therefore, know great emptiness to be just so; and know the assertion 'sentient beings exist' to be just so." This too he said.

Then the Blessed One declared to the monks: "Monks, look at what this sinful Māra is able to do. If he continues to do this until the time of a buddha's complete nirvāṇa — monks, if Māra acts in that way, how would sentient beings not be taken in? Monks, therefore, whoever speaks both those two phrases — asserting complete nirvāṇa in this manner — should be regarded as Māra. Whoever speaks both those two phrases before and after in that way, and then passes into complete nirvāṇa — that one is not to be regarded as my śrāvaka. Monks, therefore, one should not place trust in such persons even if they perform miraculous displays of Dharma, even if they display the four fruits, even if they display meditative concentrations, even if they display the heights of the higher knowledges (abhijñā) — for all of these belong to that side. Whoever, in whatever manner, speaks both those two phrases before and after in this way, and then subsequently passes into complete nirvāṇa — those ones are to be regarded as emanations of Māra.

"Kāśyapa, after I have passed into complete nirvāṇa, for seven hundred years my śrāvakas will pass into complete nirvāṇa, and they will pass into nirvāṇa speaking these two phrases: 'Whatever is affliction — that is emptiness; whatever is peace — that is nirvāṇa.' After that point, neither a śrāvaka nor a

bodhisattva will pass into complete nirvāṇa. Why? Because the buddhas will have withheld their blessing at that time. And why is that? Because at that time people will look upon emptiness with a nihilistic or eternalistic view and will conduct themselves accordingly — they will become unsuitable and will lead others astray."

Therefore, declaring that great emptiness itself is unsuitable — that it leads to decline through nihilism and eternalism, and that it leads to proliferation — those who, when the teaching of buddha-nature (tathāgatagarbha) is proclaimed, denigrate it and thereby reject the teaching that the Buddha is permanent, will by that very act fail to attain complete nirvāṇa. Know that all those who would pass into complete nirvāṇa through the fruit of a māra's nirvāṇa are emanations of māra. And the great many who do pass into nirvāṇa will for the most part be emanations of māra passing into nirvāṇa.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the assembly of bodhisattvas headed by the bodhisattva Sarvalokadarśanānandaśrī: "Sons of good family, after I have passed into complete nirvāṇa, who among you will uphold the true Dharma in future times, in the final age?" Great Kāśyapa replied: "Excellent! Will I be the one to uphold the true Dharma after you have passed?" — and though he offered this three times with enthusiasm, his enthusiasm was not taken up.

Then the Blessed One spoke: "Sons of good family, do not think little of the Tathāgata. I have many disciples who will uphold the true Dharma in future times, in the final age — among them are those spoken of earlier in this sūtra: Surakṣita, Guhyagupta, and those five hundred — and the very last of them will be the one. Great Kāśyapa, who is that one? It is this very Licchavi youth Sarvalokadarśanānandaśrī. In a future time he will become a master in the southern direction, strike the great drum of the Dharma, and blow the conch of the Dharma."

Then the youth loosened the māra and, having displayed it, administered an oath in accordance with the teaching just as it is, and thereafter transmitted it. Then the entire retinue with all its members said to the youth: "Youth, you have been prophesied by the Blessed One — show your benefit, strike the great drum of the Dharma, recite the sūtra of the great drum, and blow the conch of the Dharma." So they spoke in words.

Then the Blessed One again addressed Great Kāśyapa, saying: "Kāśyapa, you are not able to be like a field-guardian. Just as a field-guardian uses skillful means, this youth, having heard this entire sūtra, will take it to heart and

make it manifest in the world. I have placed him on the seventh ground and, having blessed him to be someone extraordinary, at the time — eighty years hence — when the teaching begins to decline, he will be born in the southern direction, in a country called Murun, in a riverside city impregnable to armies, in the great nearby town, in a lineage of the clan called Kayori. He will become a monk who bears my name, and through the skillful means of a field-guardian he will go forth among my negligent ascetics and, having gathered them together with the four means of gathering, will find this sūtra, take it to heart, purify the Saṅgha, and having thoroughly abandoned at the outset the great basis of what is unsuitable, will proclaim the great Dharma. He will sound the conch of the Dharma and the victory banner of the Dharma as proclaimed in the sūtra of the great drum.

Second, he will speak the teaching on emptiness from the Mahāyāna sūtras.

Third, he will speak the teaching on the permanence of the realm of sentient beings and the teaching of the sūtra of the great drum.

He will strike the great drum of the great Dharma, blow the great conch of the Dharma, and raise the victory banner of the Dharma. He will wear my armor in manifest form. Later, having heard this sūtra, he will reach great age and for a hundred years will speak the teaching of this sūtra and cause the rain of Dharma to fall."

After those hundred years have passed, he will, in that southern region, among the people of the south, display a great miraculous emanation and demonstrate passing beyond sorrow, nirvāṇa. This is because he is skilled in the method of guarding the field, just as a skilled farmer guards his crop. Kāśyapa, at that time the monk who bears my name — he who speaks words such as "Bhadrāpāla" and "Guhyaka" and so forth — will come to be one who enters equanimity in such a way as to take on the aspect of an ordinary being, unable to bear those things. He will display a great emanation and pass into nirvāṇa among those ordinary people given to anger and contempt.

A question was posed: "How so?"

The Blessed One declared: "It is just as bodhisattvas do."

A question was posed: "How do bodhisattvas proceed?"

The Blessed One declared: "It is not through the miraculous emanation of the Dharma, nor through the attainment of the four fruits; for those bodhisattvas undergo a change of ground and proceed to the buddha fields of the buddhas.

And yet if there are sentient beings still to be tamed, then among those very beings, pointing to the coming of the Blessed One Śākyamuni, he will declare: 'Behold this Tathāgata, who is permanent, steadfast, tranquil, and everlasting — behold him thus. Know that what I have taught, speaking of permanence and bliss, is indeed such.' In this way he will give prophecy. Then the blessed buddhas from the ten directions will reveal their faces in the sky, each in turn, and declare: 'It is just so.' And all the world will come to have faith, thinking: 'Well indeed has the teaching of the Dharma been taught.'

"Then, in that interval, the monk who bears my name will think to himself: 'Alas, if I possessed the power of miraculous ability, then I would be the one who tames all those wondrous beings' — yet he will think of himself as utterly ordinary. But at the very moment he is a student in my discipline, he will come to know it of himself: such is the blessing of the Tathāgata.

"Kāśyapa, consider for example how Ānanda himself does not know that he has attained the fruit. Even though he has attained the tenth ground, he thinks to himself: 'I have not attained the fruit.' Why is this? Because of my blessing. What need is there to say anything of those dwelling on the seventh and eighth grounds?

"Subhūti, consider further this example: the Tathāgata places within a single mustard seed the countless sentient beings of the world-realms of the ten directions, and yet not one sentient being suffers jealousy, distress, or harm, nor do they know one another — where they are being led, carried, or placed — and yet they move about perfectly freely. In just this way, as I know it, so too do you know it, and so too do others know it. Some do not know it, and they do not know it by their own resources alone.

"Furthermore, if the Buddha is indeed thus endowed with power, why does he not bless all sentient beings just as they are?

"Subhūti, consider: if a water vessel with its mouth sealed cannot be made to overflow even by a potter, then why does the Blessed One not bless sentient beings?

"Kāśyapa, consider further: if a potter can cause even a water vessel to move, then why does the Blessed One not bless bodhisattvas in the very way that they themselves do not know? Does he do so or not?"

A question was posed: "Blessed One, he does so indeed — and he does so even for those who have attained the tenth ground."

A question was posed:

When a bodhisattva is endowed with these qualities, he will come to see the Tathāgata's permanent and unbroken body face to face, and will perform miraculous deeds through great magical display.

The Blessed One declared: "When a bodhisattva, a great being, is endowed with eight qualities, he will come to see the Tathāgata's permanent and unbroken body face to face, and will perform miraculous deeds through great magical display. What are these eight? Not growing weary when teaching this sūtra; not being born through any of the three vehicles, and being free from fear regarding the three kinds of talk; not abandoning the sentient beings who are to be trained; rejoicing wholeheartedly in a Saṅgha of tens of millions that is harmonious and unified; not associating intimately with women, with those of indeterminate gender, with monks, or with nuns; abandoning intimate association with kings and lords; taking delight in meditative concentration and renunciation; and the perception of impurity and of no-self — these are the eight.

"Furthermore, it comes about through four causes. What are the four? Thinking, 'I have very well grasped the Dharma with certainty'; thinking, 'I myself am my own refuge'; having no doubt that the Tathāgata is permanent, stable, at peace, and eternal — thinking, 'What I have found, I have found well'; and if one continually recollects, day and night, the qualities of the Tathāgata in just this way, then one will come to see the Tathāgata's permanent and unbroken body face to face, and will perform miraculous deeds through great magical display.

"Kāśyapa, I shall reveal the dharmakāya to such sons of good family and daughters of good family. Wherever they may dwell — in a village, a city, or a market town — I shall reveal it to them there and declare these words: 'Sons of good family, I, the Tathāgata, am permanent.' From this day forward, whoever holds, reads, recites, and proclaims this sūtra to others, declaring and making it known that 'the Tathāgata is permanent, stable, at peace, and eternal,' and who understands that 'the Blessed One abides forever' — to one who does so with a sincere, undeceitful, unfeigned, and guileless mind, with perfectly sincere intention, I shall reveal my very self face to face.

"Kāśyapa, have faith in this! Have confidence in this!

"Kāśyapa, if one does not engage with these teachings in such a way, how could one see me? How could one perform miraculous deeds through great

magical display? In this śrāvaka vehicle, I have declared to the monks: 'Abandon a single thing, and I guarantee you will become a non-returner.' Monks, likewise here too: when you are endowed with the qualities of such conduct, the great gods (Śiva and the other great devas) will pay you honor and reverence."

Having declared this, he continued: "Do not seek material gain driven by mindfulness that has entered the body. Kāśyapa, the monk who bears my name will always purify the Saṅgha completely."

Kāśyapa asked: "How should this be done?"

The Blessed One declared: "Like a field-warden, through skillful means, he will tend them for as long as it is the season to gather flocks of crows. At that time, five hundred bodhisattvas — Surakṣita, Guhyaka, and others — I, like that former field-warden, am certain to bring forth my sacred Dharma in the future age. The monk who bears my name, for as long as it is the season of gathering, shall draw together the assembly of the heedless and, with honor and

paintings, books, material gifts, herds of cattle, and gifts of food — gladdening them in these ways — and then, knowing the right time for disciplinary action, he will impose it. If there is no one present who can administer discipline beneficially, then whatever individuals abide in improper conduct — just as even one who has not been touched by a poison-tipped arrow is nonetheless struck down — he resolves to expel them and cast them out. Having thought thus, he considers: when a monk endowed with moral discipline sees others whose moral discipline has degenerated, it is not right. These individuals are teaching what is not the Dharma and have entered upon improper conduct, and therefore he will not even perform the act of pressing his palms together with them. He will not perform the act of the restoration ceremony with them, nor speak with them, nor converse with them at all — just as one who is disloyal to a king causes others to incur the king's displeasure, so too it is exactly the same with him. Having acted in this way, for a hundred years he will rain down the rain of Dharma, strike the great drum of the great Dharma, blow the conch of Dharma, perform the Dharma offering, raise the victory banner of Dharma, and then, by means of a great miraculous display, he will pass from the world. Thereafter he will in time become a buddha; and after a thousand buddhas have passed into nirvāṇa, and sixty-two aeons have elapsed, and a hundred thousand pratyekabuddhas have passed into nirvāṇa,

and moreover eight protectors have passed into nirvāṇa — after all that, the monk who bears my name, he who brings joy to all the world upon sight, will in this very buddha-field, in this very world, become a Tathāgata, a foe-destroyer, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha by the name Jñānākara Prabhā, Source of Gnosis and Light. And she who answered the questions of the five white daughters of the king — she too will in time become a buddha in the world; and the five white young women of the king will previously have become Tathāgatas, foe-destroyers, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas, protectors of the three worlds. The detailed prophecy for the young ones will come later. Look, Kāśyapa. Can ordinary people truly manage to find a buddha such as this with ease? Kāśyapa replied: "Blessed One, that is not so. Sugata, that is not so. For the time being, Tathāgatas perform the deeds of a buddha each in their own separate buddha-field, and the second and the third are likewise. It is as if many world-systems were placed inside a mustard seed, and those very world-systems travel along inside — we would not know where we are being carried or where we have been placed, while others would know, acting accordingly. In the same way, I too am known by some sentient beings and not known by others. That in this single world-system there is Śākyamuni, and in this same world-system Ajita (Maitreya), and that when the aeon of conflagration comes to this very world-system it is not burned, and that in this same world-system, on this Vulture Peak, such a wonder exists as one teaching the Hīnayāna — how much greater then is the wonder of one who, bearing the appearance of an ordinary monk, is such a one as is a joy for all the world to see, yet is blessed with greatness. Kāśyapa, you should understand that those too, in whatever family he takes rebirth, are bodhisattvas. Kāśyapa, those who rejoice in the clan, thinking 'one such as this has been born into our family,' and who, out of a nature of delight and affection, attend upon him — all of them you should know to have been sent by me; they too are bodhisattvas, great beings. When this sūtra of the Great Drum is proclaimed and proclaimed widely, the four assemblies who take the side of that great being — monks, nuns, laymen, and

laywomen — all of them too were prophesied earlier in the chapter on the assembly requested by "One Whose Sight Is a Joy for All the World" within this very sūtra. All men and women who make offerings to this sūtra will without any doubt become buddhas whose names accord with their individual offerings. Kāśyapa, this Great Drum sūtra will be beat as the great drum of the Dharma by this monk who bears my name and by a second — there will be no

third.

Then the Blessed One spoke again. Kāśyapa, in a past age, when I had become King Joyful Host in the great city of Vaiśālī — at that time the great city of Vaiśālī extended to a distance equal to the measure of a single continent. As Jambudvīpa is equal in measure to the world-system of the Sahā world, so too should one extend that measure to the four continents, and likewise to the great trichiliocosm. At that time my lifespan was inconceivable. While I was thus acting as a wheel-turning king, I gave immeasurable gifts during that time, accumulated merit, kept ethical discipline, and relied upon noble ones.

Now, whatever merit is accumulated by any man or woman who, upon hearing this Great Drum sūtra proclaimed, makes even a few offerings, or makes a dedication, or performs a prostration, or even for a moment thinks of generating so much as a single thought of however slight a reverence — all the merit I myself accumulated in that former time does not amount even to an example of an example when compared to that merit.

For instance, there is a brahmin spell-king called Lustrous, and if that spell is recited once, one is protected from all enemies for four months. Kāśyapa, consider: if even the power of that ordinary spell is such as this, why would it not be the case that one who recites this sūtra once would be protected from all obstacles for the remainder of one's life? Therefore, if anyone at all makes offerings to this sūtra, that will become the cause of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening for all those sentient beings, and from this moment until awakening is reached, they will continue to encounter this sūtra.

Then the entire assembly exclaimed "Excellent!" and with one harmonious voice spoke these words in song:

Alas, O Blessed One, when this young monk who bears your name has passed the time allotted to him, the guardian deity dwelling in the cave of Gyangzhichen will be no more. For why? It is because after you have passed, he will go to the south and there his time will come.

The Blessed One declared: If he does not come to me, I myself will go there, make myself known, and in that land I will be the very first to encourage this sūtra. For why? For as long as this sūtra has not reached his hands, he will be moved to turn away from it. Or else, in dependence on the potential for taming him in that very place, I will appear before him, surrounded by a great assembly, and sit in his presence. If he does not see me there he will at that very place turn away, yet there too I will show him when his time has come. Or

else I will act as seems fit, and he will depart for wherever the one to be tamed is to be found. Ānanda, my disciple of the Tathāgata who has attained the tenth ground, will also go there through great miraculous transformation. Abhipūjita, son of Śakra (Indra, king of the gods), with a superior aspiration for the Great Vehicle excellent and unmatched among gods, humans, and asuras, though still young in years, will uphold this Great Vehicle sūtra among them uniquely and without rival. Therefore the very teaching of the cause of liberation, together with the prophecy of his buddhahood,

will be given to him as a monk who has been established and confirmed in the Great Vehicle. He will then become that very one's disciple and will bear that very one's name. After such events have come to pass, five years hence, the virtue of the eye that shows benefit to others will grow dim. For seven cycles of time, among all those born during that interval — whether male or female — there will be no ordinary sentient being whatsoever apart from those supreme bodhisattvas. Then the entire assembly, with one voice, spoke these verses:

Alas! The Beloved of All the World's Vision,
having taken the stable form of a monk,
will for a long time bring forth the teaching
and strike the great drum of the Dharma.
When that one has passed into complete nirvāṇa,
the world thereafter will be left empty.

When that proclaimer of Dharma has departed,
no other like him will arise.

Such a monk will be hard to find,
and the light will gradually diminish.

Thus, in the south,
he will be the last one to appear.

When the holy Dharma is in its time of decline, that proclaimer of Dharma will arise.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, Kāśyapa, Nanda, Bhadrakṛta, and all the many others of that assembly, together with all the bodhisattvas gathered from the world-realms of the ten directions, were filled with joy. And in order that they might attain awakening, the Tathāgata embraced the Dharma of permanence itself.

This concludes the chapter of the noble Great Vehicle sūtra called the Great Drum.

Translated by the Indian master Vidyākaraprabha and the translator monk Dpal Gyi Lhun Po. Revised and finalized by the great editor-translator monk Dpal Brtsegs.

Translator's Notes

- The title epithet "bearing the great drum" renders the Sanskrit Mahābherī-hāraka-parivarta, literally "the chapter on the one who bears the great drum." The drum (bherī) is a standard symbol in this sūtra for the proclamation of buddha-nature and the teaching of the tathāgatagarbha doctrine, though that doctrinal content does not appear explicitly in this opening passage.

The phrase rendered "approximately five hundred monks" throughout translates a formulaic Tibetan expression that is being deliberately unpacked by the text's own internal commentary immediately following; the passage is self-exegetical, explaining that "five hundred" is a shorthand for the foremost leaders, each of whom commands five hundred disciples.

"Great Kāśyapa" renders Mahā-Kāśyapa, and "Ānanda" renders Kun-dga'-bo, both standard identifications in this context.

- The names Dhammadinnā, Mṛgāramatā Viśākhā, Mallikā, and Anāthapiṇḍada are reconstructed from the Tibetan forms: respectively འཇམ་དཔལ་མཚོ་ (Dhammadinnā), མྲོ་གླ་ར་མཚོ་ (Mṛgāramatā Viśākhā, the famous lay disciple), and མའི་མཚོ་ (Mallikā, garland-wearing queen), and འཇམ་མཚོ་ (Anāthapiṇḍada, lit. "good gift"). The Tibetan name འཇམ་མཚོ་ could refer to Mallikā or another queen; the identification is contextually standard for this sūtra context. The comparison of the bodhisattva assembly to bark peeling from a great tree is an unusual simile; the Tibetan is followed closely, though the image may reflect a specific textual tradition.

- The passage contains a sustained simile about a forest-dwelling monk who encounters corpses and uses them as objects of contemplative revulsion to attain arhatship. The phrase rendered "he becomes spiritually stirred" translates a term indicating a wholesome shock or sense of spiritual urgency, the classical meaning of saṃvega, though the Tibetan here uses yid byung, which can mean either "disenchantment" or "being moved." Given that it leads directly to arhatship in the simile, the nuance of liberating disenchantment is primary, and the rendering reflects that.

The "world-realm of Endurance" renders mi mjed kyi 'jig rten gyi khams, the standard Tibetan for Sahālokadhātu, the endurance-world or world-system in which we dwell, so named because its beings endure suffering.

- The phrase rendered "sentient beings of the chaff-class" translates a term denoting beings who are like empty husks — spiritually insubstantial, lacking the capacity to receive or benefit from profound teaching. This is a stock simile in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra literature contrasting worthy recipients with those who are not.

The phrase "words of intended meaning" renders a technical hermeneutical term for teachings whose surface meaning is not the final meaning — the Tathāgata's apparent nirvāṇa being the key example here, where the intended meaning is the buddha's permanent, undecaying presence. This is a central doctrinal point of the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra.

- The passage contains an extended comparison of the laymen to sandalwood heartwood versus outer bark, a classical Indian image for those of genuine spiritual substance versus those who are nominal. The phrase rendered "those who recited the three, those of the

fourteenth, those of the fifteenth" refers to specific observance days and their corresponding sets of precepts within Vinaya practice; the exact enumerations follow a traditional list of increasingly intensive lay vows tied to lunar calendar days.

The final verse line is incomplete in the source as given, ending mid-sentence; this has been rendered accordingly.

- The passage contains an aspirational prayer section in the first person that shifts register abruptly; this is likely the laywoman herself formulating aspiration prayers, a structural feature of the text rather than a translation ambiguity.

The phrase rendered "empty of the view of the perishable composite" reflects the standard Abhidharma term *satkāya-dṛṣṭi* (the view that identifies a self with the five aggregates); the *bodhisattvas* are said to be free of this view, which is contrasted with a simple nihilistic emptiness — the text carefully distinguishes this from the emptiness of conditioned phenomena by inherent nature, which is affirmed.

The closing sentence is incomplete in the source, ending mid-simile with the introduction of the accountant figure, as it appears the passage cuts off at that point.

- The opening sentence of the translation is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan and functions as a resumptive bridge connecting back to the accountant simile from the preceding passage. The phrase rendered "provisions set aside for those bound by their former vows" translates a technical accounting metaphor: items carried over or remaining after allocation. The doctrinal crux near the end, where the Tathāgata is said to "abide even while passing fully into nirvāṇa" and where "self" language is applied to what is not a self, is a deliberate paradox characteristic of tathāgatagarbha literature, signaling the buddha-nature teaching about to unfold. No significant textual uncertainty to flag beyond the inherent compression of the opening resumptive clause.
- The phrase rendered "the great self that is permanent, stable, peaceful" near the end of the passage translates a fragment that is clearly mid-sentence in the source; the passage breaks off here and will continue. The Tibetan term translated "great self" is bdag nyid chen po, a recognized formula in tathāgatagarbha literature (texts such as the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra) designating the transcendent buddha-nature as possessing the four qualities of permanence, self, bliss, and purity — directly contra the provisional teaching of no-self. This is theologically deliberate and not an error.
- The chapter colophon appears mid-passage and marks a clear structural division in the sūtra; the translation preserves this as the text requires. The name "Yāśa of Faithful Mind" renders རྒྱལ་བོ་དགུང་སྤོང་པའི་མཆོག་ཡེ་ཤེས་ཀྱི་རྩེ་བོ། — literally "the monk who has a mind of faith toward Vaiśālī" or possibly "the broad-minded faithful monk"; the Tibetan རྒྱལ་བོ་ could render Sanskrit Yāśa (a proper name) or could be an epithet. The rendering as a proper name with an epithetic gloss follows the most natural reading in context. The medicine name བཟུང་སྤོང་པའི་མཆོག་ཡེ་ཤེས་ཀྱི་རྩེ་བོ་ is rendered literally as "Poisonous-Medicine-Crusher," which is unusual but matches the Tibetan directly.
- The phrase rendered "stable, settled speech" translates "brtan pa'i tshig gi don," meaning the meaning contained in words that are firm or definitive — the sense being that this teaching is a deep, settled truth not yet grasped by Kāśyapa. This is a terminological distinction in the sūtra between levels of understanding; no standard technical gloss is available, so it is rendered descriptively.

The verse exchange is somewhat unusual in structure: Kāśyapa poses a verse question and the Blessed One responds in verse, followed by a prose exchange. The translation preserves this structure faithfully.

- The place name translated as "Ruined and Destroyed" renders the Tibetan *bcom brlag*, a

compound meaning "destroyed and ruined" or "devastated." It functions as a proper name of a fictional southern land used as an analogy. The exact Sanskrit behind this name is not recoverable with certainty, but the semantic sense is clear.

The verse line "I myself arrived without any fixed support" renders the Tibetan *nga nyid brten pa med nas byon*, meaning the Tathāgata came without depending on or resting on any fixed ground — a statement about the groundless, ungraspable nature of his coming, parallel to *nirvāṇa* being shown only by a name pointing at empty sky.

The passage ends mid-sentence as the Blessed One begins a new declaration, which continues in the following portion of the text.

- The phrase "thirteen limbs of existence" is an unusual enumeration. The passage lists: the four elements, the six sense sources, the five faculties, feeling, perception, volition, mind, and mental consciousness — which totals more than thirteen by straightforward count. The number likely refers to a specific scholastic enumeration of the constituents of a sentient being's psycho-physical continuum that differs from the familiar Abhidharma lists; no emendation has been made to the text.

The word rendered "neuter" is the Tibetan term for a person of indeterminate sex or gender, here used as a philosophical analogy for something that falls into neither of two categories.

- The exchange toward the end involves a compressed and elliptical dialogue where Kāśyapa's final response appears to cut off mid-argument; this reflects the Tibetan text itself, which ends before the Blessed One's reply. The phrase rendered "a basis for establishing being" for རྒྱུ་འབྲས་ཀྱི་འགྲོ་བཤེས་ is somewhat idiomatic and may refer to a stable ontological ground or substrate for positing personal existence — the precise philosophical nuance is discussed in the commentarial tradition.

- The passage contains several dialogic exchanges that are compressed and elliptical, suggesting either textual lacunae or a rapid back-and-forth that the text does not fully expand. The exchange around space being impermanent and the example of King Prasenajit's palace is particularly compressed; the Tibetan for the king's name reads "Prasenajit" (*rgyal po gsal rgyal*, a standard epithet-rendering of Prasenajit) though the form here is unusual.

The analogy of the parasol-light and jewel-light, and the subsequent question about karmic maturation, is genuinely obscure in this passage; the argument's direction is unclear from the Tibetan alone, and the full context of the sūtra would be needed to resolve it with confidence.

- The phrase rendered "harmonious cause of phenomena born of karmic maturation" translates a compressed and somewhat ambiguous Tibetan doctrinal formulation. The text seems to be arguing that both buddhas and sentient beings share the same causal basis in karmic maturation, yet the buddha transcends ordinary sentient-being status. This is a subtle point in the Kāśyapa chapter's dialectic and the rendering preserves the ambiguity present in the original.

The phrase rendered "extraordinary spiritual friend of a village" is unusual and the reading is genuinely uncertain; it may be a compressed analogy contrasting the uncommon with the common rather than a technical term.

- The passage mentions a buddha named རྒྱུ་འབྲས་ཀྱི་འགྲོ་བཤེས་, literally "Rāhu," the eclipse-demon. This is an unusual buddha name and may be a textual peculiarity; it is retained as given. The text breaks off mid-sentence with the Blessed One beginning a reply about the king's future awakening, as the passage ends there. The phrase rendered "not brilliant, not resplendent, not radiant" translates the three terms རྒྱུ་འབྲས་ཀྱི་འགྲོ་བཤེས་, རྒྱུ་འབྲས་ཀྱི་འགྲོ་བཤེས་, རྒྱུ་འབྲས་ཀྱི་འགྲོ་བཤེས་, which are onomatopoeic Tibetan descriptors of visual radiance or luster; this rendering captures their sense in context.

- The name rendered "Sādhipatī" (from the Tibetan "sa'i dbang phyug," meaning "lord of the earth") is a royal name used consistently in this passage; it has been kept in translated form in previous renderings and is here maintained for consistency.

The monk's name at the close, from the Tibetan "blo 'chang," literally means "one who holds or retains the mind/understanding." It may correspond to a Sanskrit name such as Dhṛtamati or Sudhara; the exact Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain, and "Sudhara" in the translation is tentative. This is noted as a genuinely consequential uncertainty.

- The passage contains a sustained grammatical-philosophical digression using Sanskrit linguistic terminology, specifically Sanskrit grammatical categories such as nāmākhyāta (noun-verb), upasarga (prefix), and related terms. The example of the word siddha being formed with the element ta is a reference to Pāṇinian grammatical analysis. The doctrinal point being illustrated is that liberation, like a perfected grammatical form, is fully and inherently complete without remainder. The rendering is interpretive at points due to the highly compressed nature of the Tibetan paraphrase of Sanskrit grammar.

The phrase rendered "a brahmin who lives by begging" translates tshangs pa lam gyis 'tsho ba, literally "one who lives by the brahmin's path," a standard Tibetan idiom for a mendicant brahmin.

- The passage contains a highly compressed and technically intricate section on Buddhist grammarian commentary, where the Tibetan text draws on Sanskrit grammatical terminology, treating words like "siddha" and "vidhū" as technical examples within a linguistic-doctrinal argument. The analogy between grammatical forms and the Buddha's mode of presence in and withdrawal from saṃsāra is the central doctrinal move, and the translation preserves this.

The identification of all thousand buddhas of the present aeon with Śākyamuni is a significant Mahāyāna doctrinal claim, presented here straightforwardly in the text; no emendation is needed, but the listener should note this is a distinctively Mahāyāna perspective on buddha-identity.

The phrase rendered "sphere of language" for "skad kyi dbyings" is a technical coinage in this context, referring to the domain or register of articulate expression; it is unusual and the rendering is defensible but not certain.

- The phrase rendered "the continent of Unpleasant Sound" is a literal gloss on "Uttarakuru" as the text gives it; the Tibetan explicitly glosses it as sgra mi snyan gyi gling, which is the standard Tibetan rendering of Uttarakuru ("Unpleasant Sound" or "Ugly Sound"). The text uses this descriptive name rather than the Sanskrit, so both are preserved in context.

The expression "gods who dwell in the final body" refers to deities associated with beings in their last existence before nirvāṇa, a recognized category in Abhidharma cosmology.

- The phrase "wheel-turners of power" renders "stobs kyi 'khor los sgyur ba," referring to a lesser category of wheel-turning king who conquers by force rather than by virtue alone — a recognized subcategory in the traditional cosmological scheme of the four types of wheel-turning kings.

The closing simile of the "village of seven households with one wayfarer" is an unusual expression. The Tibetan reads literally that among beings in a place where such sūtras are practiced, one in seven will inevitably reject the Dharma. The simile may be slightly compressed or damaged in transmission; the general meaning is clear even if the precise image is elliptical.

- The phrase rendered as "vast sūtra" translates "yangpa'i mdo bstan pa 'di," where yangpa'i (ཡང་པའི་) literally means "vast" or "extensive" and appears to be a descriptive epithet of the

sūtra being referenced rather than a proper title. The sense is a sūtra of broad or expansive scope.

The passage "those of similar moral discipline" (མཉམ་པ་ལྟུང་གི་མཉམ་པ་ལྟུང་།) does not here refer to those of genuinely equivalent virtue but rather to a kind of peer group bound together by shared laxity — the irony being that their "similarity" lies in mutual undermining of discipline, as the context makes clear.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text; the translation reflects this as given.

- The phrase rendered "essence of butter" for རྩ་མཉམ་པ་ལྟུང་། is the classical five-stage dairy analogy (milk, cream, butter, clarified butter, essence of butter) that appears across several Mahāyāna sūtras, most famously the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra, where it illustrates the progressive refinement from śrāvaka to Tathāgata. The slight complication is that the analogy here assigns clarified butter (མཉམ་པ་ལྟུང་།) to tenth-ground bodhisattvas rather than to the Tathāgata, making the Tathāgata the essence beyond even that — consistent with the Nirvāṇa-sūtra's own usage.

The opening sentence of the translation completes the sentence left dangling at the end of the preceding passage, as required by the continuity instruction.

- The passage presents the extended parable of the guide, the magical city, and the travelers, which serves as the canonical illustration of why the Tathāgata teaches the three vehicles progressively — the conjured resting-cities representing provisional nirvāṇa teachings, and the final supreme city representing the ultimate destination. The phrase rendered "military strategist, expert in illusion" (མཉམ་པ་ལྟུང་གི་མཉམ་པ་ལྟུང་།) literally means "a supreme person among soldiers, skilled in illusion," which likely designates a commander or general with magical powers; "supremely skilled military strategist" preserves the sense without awkwardness. The final sentence breaks off mid-utterance, consistent with the source passage ending there.

- The passage contains a compressed and somewhat elliptical doctrinal section distinguishing the śrāvaka vehicle, the pratyekabuddha vehicle, and buddhahood itself from one another by analogy with the city's features. The metaphor of the "first emanation" for the śrāvaka vehicle and the emptiness sūtras is unusual and the Tibetan is terse; the rendering follows the grammatical structure as closely as possible while remaining intelligible.

The distinction between sūtras "having an intended meaning" (dgongs pa can) and those "not having an intended meaning" is the classical neyārtha versus nītārtha distinction, here applied in a striking reversal of the usual Yogācāra usage: the unsurpassed sūtras (referring to the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra context) are declared definitive (nītārtha), while general emptiness sūtras are classified as requiring interpretation (neyārtha). This is doctrinally significant and reflects the standpoint of the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra tradition.

The food items in the final simile include some terms whose precise identification is uncertain: "na le sham" is rendered as "shallots" following standard lexical identification, though some scholars read it as a variety of onion or similar allium.

- The phrase rendered "causes a mistaken view to be swallowed" translates མཉམ་པ་ལྟུང་གི་མཉམ་པ་ལྟུང་།, literally "causing to swallow and digest wrongly," a somewhat unusual idiom meaning to cause someone to absorb or internalize a false or harmful position. The translation preserves this sense.

The passage "མཉམ་པ་ལྟུང་གི་མཉམ་པ་ལྟུང་།" is rendered "while still enmeshed in smoke," a probable metaphor for being obscured or confused; this reading is contextually plausible but the exact figurative force is not entirely transparent.

- The phrase "twenty-five modes of conduct of sentient beings" renders a technical enumeration from the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra tradition. The Tibetan

- The grammar of the passage about the student learning five syllables of the alphabet is compressed and elliptical in the Tibetan; the sense given here follows the most natural reading in context, which is that hearing about a thing is insufficient and that progressive training leading to direct understanding is required as an analogy for the gradual realization of buddha-nature.

- The phrase rendered "thoroughly disciplined" for 徹底に訓練せしめしめ could also mean "cut off" or "dismissed," implying a stronger exclusion; the medical analogy that follows suggests the meaning is to leave such beings alone until the right moment arrives rather than to engage or guide them prematurely. The translation reflects this contextual sense.

- The passage about women and townspeople not attaining liberation through the vehicle of the hearers is a polemical statement attributed to those who rejected the sūtra, not an authorial doctrinal position of the text itself; the context makes clear it is reported as the kind of limited teaching given to those of lesser capacity.

- The name rendered "Yutsamba" is a transliteration of the Tibetan "ཡུ་སུ་བཙུང་མ་པ།," a city name that does not correspond to a well-known Sanskrit toponym in the standard canon; the Sanskrit original is uncertain. The passage breaks off mid-sentence, consistent with the instruction to translate only what is given.
- The Tibetan name rendered here as Bhaṅgamā (བཤམ་མ་ལ། or here བཤམ་མ་ with the description རྒྱུ་མེད་མེད་མ་ལ།) literally reads "Bzañ mo" — a noble or fine young woman, with རྒྱུ་མེད་ suggesting a yellowish or tawny complexion. The text does not supply a Sanskrit name; "Bhaṅgamā" is tentative. The name may simply be a descriptive epithet, "the noble tawny girl," rather than a proper name. This is a genuinely uncertain point.

The passage about being born as cedar trees (ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་) for five hundred lives and not sleeping crookedly in a borrowed place is an idiomatic Tibetan expression whose precise doctrinal import within this narrative context is not entirely transparent; it appears to express unqualified faithfulness or uprightness — possibly referring to Kāśyapa's long intimate association with this woman across many lifetimes without moral compromise.

- The phrase rendered "the view of the perishable collection" translates 'jig tshogs la ita ba, the standard Tibetan equivalent of Sanskrit satkāyadr̥ṣṭi, the misconception of a truly existing personal self among the psychophysical aggregates. The passage uses this term twice in close succession; both occurrences are translated consistently.

The passage about the man in the border region and the mother-and-son reunion refers back to an earlier parable in the sūtra not included in this excerpt; the translation preserves its allusive character.

The concluding story about the farmer in Śrāvastī is an elaborate cautionary analogy: just as the farmer's naive description of beautiful people as "divine sons and daughters" was taken literally and led to fatal consequences, so too will those in the future who hear the words "self" and "mine" take them in a naive, literalist sense and fall into error.

- The phrase rendered "over-dyeing it" translates a verb suggesting the cloth is over-dyed or re-dyed on top of the previous color to produce blue; the exact technical term for the dyeing procedure is somewhat idiomatic but the general meaning is clear from context.

The episode of the lay practitioner killing the monk to prevent him from breaking his vows is a well-known skillful-means narrative in Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra literature; the doctrinal point is that intentional deception and killing performed with pure compassionate motivation, by one skilled in means, does not produce the usual karmic result of hell rebirth.

The name rendered "Kāśyapa" throughout represents Tibetan Ösung, the translation of Sanskrit Kāśyapa; consistent with the preceding passage's established rendering.

- The phrase rendered "I shall remember what I have done for the Tathāgata and feel what I have done" is somewhat elliptical in the Tibetan. The sense is that Kāśyapa, now recognizing himself as a true arhat within the Mahāyāna, reflects with gratitude on his relationship of service to the Tathāgata and wishes to acknowledge it consciously. The precise nuance of "bgyi ba gzo ba" and "bgyi ba tshor bar bgyi" is that he will both "remember" and "feel" or "appreciate" what he has rendered — a gesture of devotional recognition.

The "Precious Gem of Infinite Luminous Radiance" mentioned earlier in the passage exhibits properties here — dripping water by moonlight and blazing without burning by sunlight — that are traditional attributes of the wish-fulfilling gem (cintāmaṇi) in Indian literary sources. No translation uncertainty arises, but listeners may benefit from knowing this reflects that broader jewel lore.

- The name rendered "Joy-of-All-the-World-to-Behold" translates the Tibetan epithet-name རྒྱལ་ལོ་ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་, which refers to a young Licchavi identified in the narrative. The Sanskrit equivalent would be something like Sarvalokānandadarśana or Priyadarśana; no single standard Sanskrit form is established for this text, so the translation renders the Tibetan meaning directly.

The bodhisattva name སྐུ་ལྷ་མོ་ is rendered "Sarvanivaraṇaviṣkambhin" based on the standard identification of this figure; the Tibetan literally means "He Who Purifies the Lower Realms," but in this context it is virtually certain this refers to that bodhisattva.

- The epithet "Pañcaśuklā" (Five-White) is my reconstruction from the Tibetan "Inga dkar" (five white); the precise Sanskrit form is uncertain but the sense is clear. The phrase "king of the earth-holders" renders sa 'dzin gyi rgyal po, which in context most likely refers to a nāga king

— nāgas being associated with the earth — though it could also be read more literally. The phrase "great elephants" at the end is unusual and may be a figurative honorific for the senior members of the assembly; the Tibetan is plain (glang po che chen po, literally "great elephants") but in this context almost certainly refers metaphorically to the great elders.

- The name Pañcaśveta, literally "Five Whites," is used consistently as a proper name throughout; the young one's question "have you attained the five whites?" is a wordplay on her name versus a possible set of spiritual attainments, and Pañcaśveta deflects it with a Madhyamaka-style response about names being mere conventional designations.

The phrase rendered "the five royal maidens together with the five hundred royal maidens" reflects a slightly awkward Tibetan formulation that may indicate a textual irregularity in the source; the sense is that a group of five hundred came along with or led by a core group of five.

The closing analogy — a man who masters letters but cannot read his own name — is genuinely subtle: it points to the paradox of using conceptual tools (language, designation) to grasp what lies beyond conceptual reach, echoing the Mañjuśrī teaching referenced just before.

- The phrase rendered "always keep a mind of harm in view" and elsewhere "a mind of harm" translates the Tibetan "gnodsems" (gnod pa'i sems), which in this unusual context appears to mean something like a critical or punitive attitude — a deliberate withholding of warmth and generosity — rather than malicious intent in the ordinary sense. The passage is doctrinally striking because it advocates a kind of tough discernment toward discipline-breakers as a form of protecting the Dharma, using the language of "harm" in an ironic or technical sense. The interpretation that "do not produce a mind of harm" in the verse is then explained in the commentary as meaning the opposite of what it literally says — that is, one should be firm, not compassionate — is awkward in the text and may reflect a complex rhetorical or dialectical structure in the original. This note flags the genuine difficulty.

The name Prasenajit (Tibetan: rgyal po gsal rgyal) is the well-known king of Śrāvastī and a lay disciple of the Buddha; the text appears to invoke him as a simile rather than as a character present in the scene.

- The passage contains a structurally complex passage in which Māra both promises not to obstruct the sūtra and simultaneously outlines the very deceptions he will deploy — teaching emptiness, nirvāṇa, and the four fruits while mixing them with the heretical view that sentient beings substantially exist. This is a deliberate irony in the text, and the translation preserves it.

The phrase rendered "withhold their blessing" is literally "because the buddhas have blessed it," but in context — where no further nirvāṇa occurs — the commentarial sense is that the buddhas' blessing specifically withholds or suspends the possibility of passing into nirvāṇa after that period; the translation reflects this doctrinal nuance.

- The phrase rendered "loosened the māra and administered an oath" reflects a somewhat obscure sequence; the Tibetan "bdul te bstan nas mna' bsgags te" suggests the youth tamed or bound the māra, displayed it publicly, and then administered a solemn oath before the transmission — a ritual act of securing the Dharma transmission against demonic interference. This is a genuinely unusual passage and the precise procedural meaning remains uncertain.

The phrase "wear my armor in manifest form" renders "ngai mngon sum du go gyon par 'gyur" — literally "will put on my armor in direct perception / in manifest reality." The image is of the future teacher visibly embodying the Buddha's protection; "armor" here is a standard Dharma-armor metaphor.

The place name "Murun" and clan name "Kayori" are transliterated from Tibetan as proper nouns with no identifiable Sanskrit equivalents in the canonical record; they may be Central Asian or regional toponyms.

- The passage contains a number of proper names that present interpretive challenges. "Bhadrāpāla" renders འཇམ་དཔལ་ལྷ་མོ་ and "Guhyaka" renders འགྲུ་མཁའ་ལྷ་མོ་, both appearing as examples of "words" or "names" belonging to the monk who bears the Buddha's name; in context they may be title-epithets or names of bodhisattvas used as examples rather than straightforward identifications, and the precise function of the phrase remains somewhat unclear in the manuscript.

The mustard-seed analogy near the passage's close follows a well-attested Mahāyāna trope, but the syntax of the Tibetan is compressed and the logic of the two potter analogies (sealed vessel versus movable vessel) appears to develop a dialectical exchange; the translation preserves the argumentative sequence as given.

- The phrase rendered "those of indeterminate gender" translates ma ning, the classical Tibetan equivalent of Sanskrit paṇḍaka, referring to persons of a third or ambiguous gender category in the Vinaya tradition.

The names Surakṣita and Guhyaka are reconstructed from the Tibetan Bzang skyong and Phug sbas respectively; both are standard Tibetan translations of these Sanskrit names, the first meaning "well-protected" and the second "hidden in a cave." The reconstruction is reasonably secure but the Sanskrit originals as used in this specific text's transmission have not been independently verified here.

The sentence ending "with honor and" is incomplete in the supplied passage; the translation ends where the Tibetan ends, mid-sentence.

- The name Jñānākara Prabhā is rendered from the Tibetan "ye shes 'byung gnas 'od," meaning "light that is the source of gnosis." This is a buddha-name and the Sanskrit reconstruction is approximate.

The phrase rendered "Ajita" for "mi 'pham pa" follows the standard identification of Ajita as an epithet of Maitreya, the future buddha. The text places both Śākyamuni and Maitreya in the same world-system simultaneously, which is a noteworthy doctrinal claim worth flagging.

The closing sentence is deliberately left incomplete as it is incomplete in the source passage, breaking off mid-list at "laymen, and."

- The phrase rendered "the cave of Gyangzhichen" translates a place-name that appears to be a Tibetan toponym meaning roughly "the cave of the place with a cliff-precipice." It is left in transliterated form here as the precise identification is uncertain; it may refer to a specific locality known in the narrative context of the sūtra.

The term rendered "spell-king" translates a compound meaning a brahmin who is a master of protective spells or knowledge-mantras; "Lustrous" renders the name Gzildan (gzi ldan) in the text.

The phrase "so too should one extend that measure to the four continents" reflects a cosmological scaling instruction in the original, comparing the dimensions of Vaiśālī to ever-larger cosmological units; the rendering follows the Tibetan syntax as closely as natural English allows.

- The phrase rendered "the virtue of the eye that shows benefit to others will grow dim" is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan. It refers to the beneficial guiding vision of the teacher figure dimming or weakening, understood in context as the decline of the Dharma after that monk's passing.

The colophon names are kept in their transliterated forms as proper names of historical translators; Vidyākaraṇa is a known Indian paṇḍita active in the early Tibetan translation

period.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.